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ETHIOPIA EDITION
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THE PHONE-FIRST EDITION

01

How to Make Your First $500 Online

A 30-Day Zero-Budget Action Plan

Pick one realistic income path and run a 30-day plan you can actually finish.

8 income paths | 30-day calendar | 22 copy-ready templates

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How to Make Your First $500 Online

A 30-Day Zero-Budget Action Plan

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Before You Spend a Dollars on Anything

How to Make Your First $500 Online where you live — 30-Day Zero-Budget Action Plan. First Edition · September 2026.

Publisher: NexKit your country Editorial Team. This course was researched, written and edited by the NexKit your country Editorial Team. It carries no individual author name and no personal credentials, because the value of the book is the method, not a personality.

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What this course is

A practical, your country-specific action plan. It describes eight realistic ways people in this country earn money online, gives you a scoring worksheet to choose one, and then walks you through thirty days of setup, proof, prospecting, outreach, delivery and payment.

It is written for a reader with a smartphone, a modest data bundle, no business licence, no TIN, no merchant account, no PayPal and no international card. Every workflow in it has a phone path and, where it helps, a laptop path.

What this course is not

It is not a promise of income. It is not legal advice, tax advice or investment advice. It is not a list of guaranteed clients, guaranteed platform approvals or guaranteed results, and it does not contain a single invented testimonial or earnings screenshot.

It cannot tell you what a bank, a wallet provider, a platform or a government office will decide about your specific case. That depends on your documents, your record and the rules in force on the day you apply.

DISCLAIMER — READ THIS ONCE, PROPERLY

This course is **educational material only**. Nothing in it is a guarantee of income, and nothing in it is financial, legal or investment advice.

$500 is a target, not a prediction. It exists to make the arithmetic concrete and to give you a way to keep score for thirty days. Many readers will earn less than that in the first month. Some will earn nothing in month one and their first income in month two. A smaller number will earn more. None of those outcomes is a verdict on you.

All prices, rates and ladders shown in this book are **illustrative examples** for teaching. You are responsible for complying with local law, your tax obligations, the terms of service of any platform you use, and the requirements of any bank, wallet or payment provider you deal with. Rules, fees, limits and country availability change, sometimes quickly.

Where the underlying research could not verify a fact, this book says so and tells you to check it yourself. Those gaps were left as gaps deliberately.

DATES, CURRENCY AND EXAMPLES

All money in this course is US US dollars (USD), written as $25. There is exactly one conversion to United States dollars in the whole book, in section 12, and it states its rate and its date on the same line.

Every business named anywhere in these pages is invented. Each is labelled **Example scenario — fictional**. No real, recognisable local company is presented as a client, a case study or a testimonial.

Every figure cited is current as of **September 2026** unless a different date is printed beside it. Source URLs for those figures appear in the **Sources & Further Reading** section at the back of the book.

BEFORE YOU RELY ON ANY OF THIS

Payment limits, wallet rules, tax thresholds and platform availability are the parts of this book most likely to go stale. Treat the numbers as a starting point for your own check, not as a substitute for it. Where this book names a rule, confirm the current version with the institution that made it.

Last updated: September 2026. Questions or corrections: use the contact address supplied with your purchase.

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HOW TO WORK THROUGH THIS COURSE

Skim the section dividers first so you can see the whole route. Then work one section at a time and finish the **DO** tasks before moving to the next. The scripts, templates and checklists are meant to be copied, filled in and sent — not admired.

FRONT MATTER

Before You Start

This book teaches one thing: how to choose a single realistic way to earn online where you live, and how to run thirty days of disciplined work towards a first payment.

What this course can help you do

— See the honest shape of the local online market, including who is actually online and who is not.

— Compare eight income paths against your own situation instead of against somebody else's.

— Choose one path and close the other seven, on purpose.

— Build a professional working identity with zero spending: Google account, clean email address, Telegram presence, a phone camera setup made from a window and a wall.

— Write an offer that a real business can say yes to.

— Build three clearly labelled sample projects so a stranger is not your first experiment.

— Price your work in dollars and know the exact words to use when someone asks how much.

— Build a list of thirty named prospects using tools that work where you live today.

— Send outreach that gets replies, and survive silence without quitting.

— Deliver work, collect money through a route that actually exists for an unlicensed individual, and turn one client into a repeat client.

What this course cannot do

READ THIS PART TWICE

This course cannot promise that you will earn $500, or any figure at all. It cannot promise that a client replies, that a platform accepts people in countries with limited payment access, that a payment provider approves you, or that a business licence is granted.

What it gives you is a method and a sequence. Most people who try to earn online where you live fail for a boring reason: they collect twelve methods, start four of them, finish none, and decide the internet does not work here. **The problem is almost never the method. It is the number of methods.** This book exists to make you run one.

A phone is enough to start

You do not need a laptop to begin. You do not need a business licence, a TIN, a merchant account, PayPal, an international card or a registered company. The startup cost assumed throughout this book is **$0**, plus whatever data you already buy.

A laptop changes the speed of some tasks — bulk photo editing, long documents, spreadsheets with hundreds of rows — but nothing in the thirty-day calendar is blocked without one. Where a task genuinely needs a laptop, this book says so on the page and gives you the workaround or tells you to borrow an hour of machine time.

WHAT YOU NEED	HONEST NOTE	COST
An Android smartphone	The core tool. Camera, Telegram, Sheets, Drive, design apps and AI chat all run here.	You have it

WHAT YOU NEED	HONEST NOTE	COST
A data bundle	Indicative third-party pricing: about $0.60 for 2 GB per month, about $5 for 30 GB. Verify current bundles with your own operator.	Your existing bundle

WHAT YOU NEED	HONEST NOTE	COST
A Google account	Gives you Gmail, Drive, Docs, Sheets and Maps on one login.	$0

WHAT YOU NEED	HONEST NOTE	COST
Telegram	Where a large share of local business conversation happens, and the cheapest way to move files on a weak connection.	$0
A wallet or bank account	a mobile wallet, a mobile-money wallet, a bank wallet, a bank wallet, a mobile wallet, Yaya or an ordinary bank savings account.	$0
Optional: laptop access	Occasional. Borrow, rent by the hour, or use a campus or library machine.	Varies

Bundle prices are indicative third-party figures and change often. One major operator raised mobile data prices by an average of about 44% in December 2025 while the other held low-income bundles unchanged, so check before you plan around a number.

Time: 60 to 90 minutes a day for 30 days

The plan in section 10 assumes **60 to 90 minutes a day**. That is between thirty and forty-five hours across the month. It is deliberately sized for a student or somebody who already works, not for somebody with unlimited time.

If you have less time, use the five-hour fast path below. If you have more, do not add a second income path. Raise your outreach volume inside the one you chose.

The free tools you may need

— **Google Drive, Docs and Sheets** — storage, documents, PDF export, and the prospect tracker that runs this whole method.

— **Google Maps** — your main prospecting surface.

— **Telegram** — outreach, delivery and file transfer on low bandwidth.

— **A free design tool** — a phone layout app or a browser-based design tool, for menus, posters and price lists.

— **A free AI chat tool** — for drafting, translating and checking your own writing. You remain the editor.

— **A free Android video editor** — CapCut, InShot or VN Editor are all live on the Play Store. InShot's watch-an-ad-to-remove-the-watermark route is genuinely useful when you have no budget.

FREE PLANS CHANGE

Free plans change. Verify the current free limits before you build a workflow on a tool. A free tier that allowed unlimited exports last year may cap you this year, and a book written in September 2026 cannot know what a tool does in March 2027.

THE MOST IMPORTANT RULE

Do not read this course without doing it.

This is not a book to finish and then start. Every section ends with something to produce: a scored worksheet, an offer, three sample projects, a list of thirty names, a sent message, a delivered file, an invoice. If you reach the end of a section without a file, a list or a sent message that did not exist before, you have not done that section.

Reading this book cover to cover while doing nothing produces exactly zero dollars and a feeling that you learned something. That feeling is the most expensive thing in the book.

Start today. Score the paths today. Send your first message before Day 15.

How to read a section

Every core lesson is built in four moves. **Explain** tells you what the idea is. **Show** gives you a concrete local example. **Do** is the action you take now. **Check** is how you know it is finished properly rather than approximately.

Two markers appear throughout. TARGET EXAMPLE means the number is arithmetic for teaching, never a prediction. NOT VERIFIED means the research could not confirm the fact, so you must check it yourself before relying on it.

Who This Is For, and Who It Is Not For

A. This is for you if

— You are 18 to 35, where you live, with a smartphone and a modest data bundle.

— You are a student, a recent graduate, under-employed, or already working and wanting a second income stream.

— You have no clients, no audience, no business licence, no TIN, no PayPal and no international card.

— You are willing to send messages to strangers and to hear no.

— You can give 60 to 90 minutes a day for thirty days.

— You want one path done properly rather than eight paths admired.

B. This is not for you if

— You want passive income with no client contact. That is not what this is.

— You want a guaranteed figure. No honest book can give you one.

— You are looking for a way to fake your location, rent an account, or receive money through an unlicensed route. Section 09 explains why those routes end badly.

— You want to trade crypto or join a virtual-asset scheme. Virtual-asset activity is prohibited where you live unless expressly authorised.

— You will not do the outreach part. Everything else in this book is preparation for the messages in section 08.

— You need money this week to eat. This plan is a month long by design, and salaried work is a legitimate and often better answer to an urgent need.

Nothing here says salaried work is failure. A salary is the most reliable income most people will ever have. This course treats online income as one additional path, not a replacement for a livelihood, and not an escape from one.

If You Only Have 5 Hours

Some readers will not run the full month. Here is the compressed version, in the correct order. Five hours, in one or two sittings.

1. **Hour 1 — Score the paths and choose one (section 02)**

   Draw the eight-criteria worksheet. Score all eight paths from 1 to 5 on each criterion. Add the totals. Circle the highest. Write the name of that path at the top of a sheet of paper and close the other seven in this book.

2. **Hour 2 — Set up identity and tracker (section 03)**

   Create or clean your Google account. Claim an email address you are happy to print on an invoice. Set a Telegram username. Create one Google Sheet, tab named Prospects, with the fifteen column headers from section 03. Create a Drive folder called Work Samples.

3. **Hour 3 — Write the offer (section 04)**

   Fill the offer template once, for one category of business. You are not writing a business plan. You are writing five sentences: what you do, for whom, what they get, what it costs, how long it takes.

4. **Hour 4 — Build one piece of proof (section 05)**

   One sample project is enough for the fast path. Photograph something, redesign it, and label it clearly: Sample — created by your name for demonstration. Not a real client. Save it in the Work Samples folder and switch link sharing to view.

5. **Hour 5 — Ten prospects and five messages (sections 07 and 08)**

   Open Google Maps. Search one category in one area. Write ten businesses into the tracker with one specific observation each. Then send five personalised first messages using the template in section 08. Five sent messages is the minimum useful sample. Send them today.

> **WHAT THE FAST PATH LEAVES OUT**
>
> It skips sections 06, 09, 10, 11 and 12. That means you may price badly, deliver without a scope note, miss the payment detail that matters, and never ask for a testimonial. Come back for those. But five hours of doing beats thirty hours of reading every time.

The $500 Question

Be exact about what this number is, because the whole book depends on you holding it correctly.

$500 is a target, not a promise and not a prediction. It appears for three reasons, and none of them is a forecast.

First, a target makes arithmetic concrete. Earn money online is not a plan. Five jobs at $12 each is a plan you can check yourself against, week by week, and adjust.

Second, a target forces a decision about volume. Most beginners price one job at $500 and then wait for one buyer. The arithmetic shows why that is a slow strategy for somebody with no track record, and why several smaller jobs usually move you further, faster.

Third, a target gives you a stopping point so you can look at what happened and decide what to repeat. Without a number, month one ends in a vague feeling.

THE HONEST PART

Many readers will earn less than $500 in thirty days. Some will earn nothing in month one and their first income in month two. That is not a failure of the method; it is the normal shape of a first month, because month one is mostly setup, proof and outreach, and paid work arrives after that.

Some readers will earn more. That is not proof the method is magic either. It usually means they already had a skill, a contact, or unusually good timing.

Your job in the next thirty days is not to hit a number. It is to end the month with a working offer, a list of prospects, a sent-message history and at least one real conversation about paid work. The number is how you keep score, not how you judge yourself.

Five Ways the Target Could Be Reached

This table is arithmetic, not forecasting. It exists so you can see how different prices change the number of buyers you need.

ROUTE TO THE TARGET	ARITHMETIC	WHAT IT DEMANDS OF YOU	STATUS
Five mid-size local jobs	5 × 2,000 = $500	Five businesses that say yes at a mid price. Realistic only after you have proof and a second or third testimonial.	TARGET EXAMPLE, NOT PREDICTION
Ten small local jobs	10 × 1,000 = $500	Volume. Ten small jobs is a lot of outreach, but each one is a small commitment for the buyer.	TARGET EXAMPLE, NOT PREDICTION
Four package jobs	4 × 2,500 = $500	A defined package, priced and described in advance. Fewer conversations, longer sales cycle.	TARGET EXAMPLE, NOT PREDICTION
Two serious projects	2 × 5,000 = $500	Two buyers with real budgets. The slowest route for a beginner and the one most people bet on by mistake.	TARGET EXAMPLE, NOT PREDICTION
Twenty micro-jobs	20 × 500 = $500	High volume, small payments, fast delivery. Good for building a review history; tiring as a month-long plan.	TARGET EXAMPLE, NOT PREDICTION

Every row is a **target example, not a prediction**. Prices are illustrative. Nothing here says any reader will reach $500, or that these are the only five routes.

HOW TO USE THIS TABLE

Pick the row that matches the price you can defend today, then work out how many buyers that row needs. Multiply that number by ten. That is roughly how many prospects you should be talking to, because a first-month reply rate on cold messages is usually low and a first-month close rate is lower.

How to Use This Course: Phone, Laptop and Low Data

Every workflow in this book is written for a phone first. Where a laptop does the job faster or better, the laptop path is printed beside it.

TASK	PHONE PATH	LAPTOP PATH
Prospect research	Google Maps app, then Google Sheets app for the tracker.	Google Maps in a browser with several tabs open; Sheets in a browser.
Photo work	Phone camera plus a free design or editing app.	Browser-based design tool; faster for batches of ten or more files.
Documents and invoices	Google Docs app, export to PDF.	Google Docs in a browser; faster for tables and page layout.
Outreach	Telegram, WhatsApp, Instagram DM, phone call.	Same, plus email if the business publishes one.
Delivery	Telegram compressed send, or a Drive link with view access.	Drive upload, then share a link.

Low-data mode

— Write before you watch. Text costs a fraction of video.

— Turn off autoplay and background sync on every app you use for work.

— Compress images before sending. Telegram's compressed photo send is usually enough for a client to approve a design, and you send the full-quality file only when it is accepted.

— Work in text-first tools. Sheets, Docs and Telegram all behave well on a weak connection.

— Do the heavy upload once, late at night, when the network is quieter. Worst-case freelancer speeds where you live have been reported as low as 98 Kb/s, worst between 16:00 and 24:00, so timing a large upload matters.

— Keep a copy of everything on the phone itself. If the connection drops, you should still be able to work.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this book you should have: one chosen income path, one written offer, three labelled samples, one prospect tracker with thirty named businesses, a sent-message history, one delivered piece of work, and one clear answer to the question of how you get paid.

01

THE HONEST SCENE

Where the Money Actually Comes From where you live

The real size and shape of the local online market, the eight income paths that exist inside it, and what each one honestly pays in a first month.

01 The market, honestly

02 What the numbers mean for you

03 Eight income paths

04 How the paths compare

05 The eight-path trap

Before you pick a path, you need to know the ground you are standing on. This section gives you the real numbers for your country, then lays out the eight ways people in this country actually earn online, with an honest first-month expectation for each.

Nothing in this section is motivational. It is a survey of the terrain, so that the choice you make in section 02 is based on the country you live in rather than the one described in internet marketing videos.

1.1 The market, honestly

your country has a population of about **136 million** people with a median age of 19.1, and about 24.3% of them live in urban areas. That is the country. Now the online part of it.

29.5m	**107m**	**9.80m**	**15%**
INTERNET USERS — 21.7% OF THE POPULATION	PEOPLE OFFLINE — 78.3%	SOCIAL MEDIA IDENTITIES — 7.2%	SMARTPHONE OWNERSHIP

Read those four numbers again slowly, because they decide your strategy. **Roughly four out of five people where you live are not online at all.** A business that sells only to people who find it on Instagram is selling to a small slice of the country, and the slice skews young, male and urban.

The gender gap is part of the picture. Smartphone ownership is 15% of the population overall, but about **6% of women against 18% of men**. If you are a woman reading this, your market is smaller, your competition among women service providers is thinner, and some clients will actively prefer to work with you. That is a real commercial fact, not a consolation.

Platform audiences are uneven. Facebook ad reach is around 9.80 million, roughly 66.8% of it male. Instagram reach is about 1.55 million. LinkedIn has around 1.80 million members and grew about 38.5% year on year. If your buyer is a business owner, LinkedIn is growing. If your buyer is a consumer, Facebook is where the country is.

The connection you are working on

Median fixed broadband download speed is about **9.37 Mbps**. Average mobile download is about **26.63 Mbps**. Those averages hide the bad hours: worst-case freelancer speeds have been reported as low as **98 Kb/s between 16:00 and 24:00**.

The design consequence is simple. Build workflows that survive a slow connection: text before video, compressed files before originals, offline drafts before live editing. A person on a weak line who plans for it will out-deliver a person on a fast line who does not.

The businesses you will sell to

Here is the number that should shape your whole plan: **more than 80% of federal business licences issued went dormant during 2025.** Most local small businesses are not durable advertisers. They open, they try, many of them stop.

That does not mean there is no market. It means the market is fragile, and a plan built on one big client is a plan built on a business that may not exist in six months. **Volume and repeat work protect you; a single whale does not.**

WHAT FOLLOWS FROM THIS

You are not entering a market of millions of ready buyers. You are entering a market where a small number of businesses have money, attention and a reason to spend, and where most do not. Your advantage is that almost nobody is doing the boring, specific follow-up work. That is the gap this book teaches you to stand in.

1.2 Eight income paths

These are the eight ways people where you live realistically convert online work into money today. Read all eight before you choose. Each card gives you the same six things: what it is, an honest first-month expectation, the skills needed, the startup cost, where the clients are, and how the money arrives.

A Freelancing

What it is: selling one specific skill to clients you never meet — writing, translation, transcription, data entry, research, simple admin, basic web tasks.

First month, honestly: usually no paid work. Month one is profile, samples and proposals. Many freelancers send dozens of proposals before the first reply that is not a no.

Skills needed: one deliverable you can produce to a deadline, plus written English good enough to be understood.

Startup cost: $0.

Where the clients are: freelance marketplaces, specialist Telegram and Facebook groups, and direct outreach. **Verify that a platform accepts people in countries with limited payment access and how it pays out before you invest weeks in it.**

How you get paid: for foreign clients, through your regulator-licensed remittance corridor. There is no verified direct PayPal, Payoneer or Stripe receiving route for a resident of a country with limited payment access. See section 09.

B Local digital services

What it is: doing digital work for businesses near you — menu and price lists, product photos, poster design, a Google Business Profile listing, a Telegram channel, a simple one-page site.

First month, honestly: the fastest path to a first dollars, because you can walk in, speak the language, and be paid the same week. Expect small amounts first.

Skills needed: basic phone photography, a free design tool, patience on the phone.

Startup cost: $0.

Where the clients are: Google Maps, walking your own neighbourhood, a local classifieds site, the online business directory, the online business directory.

How you get paid: wallet or bank transfer in dollars. This works for an individual with no business licence, inside your regulator Level 2 limits.

C AI-assisted services

What it is: using AI chat tools to produce drafts faster — product descriptions, captions, translations, summaries, CV formatting, FAQ pages — with you as the editor and quality check.

First month, honestly: sellable quickly to local businesses, provided you never hand over raw machine output. Clients pay for the editing, not for the prompt.

Skills needed: clear writing, judgement about what is wrong with a draft, and honesty about what you used.

Startup cost: $0 on free tiers. Verify current free limits before you depend on them.

Where the clients are: local businesses with bilingual needs, online sellers writing product listings, small organisations producing reports.

How you get paid: the same two routes as any service — local wallet transfer, or your regulator-licensed remittance corridor for foreign clients.

D Graphic design

What it is: logos, posters, menus, price lists, social media templates and event material, made on a phone or a browser tool.

First month, honestly: plenty of small local demand and heavy price pressure. Differentiate by speed and by delivering print-ready files, not by arguing about taste.

Skills needed: layout, type, colour discipline, and the ability to take a brief.

Startup cost: $0 on free tools; a paid design app is optional and not required.

Where the clients are: cafés, gyms, boutiques, tour operators, clinics, print shops that subcontract overflow.

How you get paid: local wallet or bank transfer. Print shops are a steady second-hand source of paid work.

E Social media management

What it is: running a business page or channel for a monthly fee — content calendar, posting, replying to messages, a short monthly report.

First month, honestly: hard to win without proof, and many small businesses stop after two or three months. The reward is that the money repeats while it lasts.

Skills needed: writing short posts in the local language or English, basic photo editing, reliability.

Startup cost: $0.

Where the clients are: businesses that post irregularly and do not reply to messages — both visible from the outside.

How you get paid: monthly wallet or bank transfer. Always agree the payment date, not only the amount.

F Digital products

What it is: making a file once and selling it many times — templates, worksheets, presets, short guides, planners.

First month, honestly: usually zero sales. Distribution is the hard part, not creation. You need an audience or a channel before the product pays.

Skills needed: making something genuinely useful, writing a description that sells it, and persistence after silence.

Startup cost: $0.

Where the buyers are: Telegram communities, existing clients, niche groups where your product solves one clear problem.

How you get paid: Telegram Stars works globally through bots with no country gate. Treat Stars as a payment rail only — withdrawing them as Toncoin is a crypto route, and virtual-asset activity is prohibited where you live unless expressly authorised.

G Content-based income

What it is: building an audience with video or writing and earning from it. Read the honest part before you commit a year to this.

First month, honestly: almost certainly nothing, and possibly nothing for a long time. **your country is not on the YouTube Partner Program availability list. TikTok Creator Rewards operates in roughly fourteen countries, none in Africa. Meta in-stream ads reached Kenya, Nigeria and Ghana, and your country was not included.**

Skills needed: consistency over months, and a plan that does not depend on ad revenue.

Startup cost: $0, but the real cost is time.

Where the money actually is: services, digital products, sponsorships, lead generation, consulting and community — not ad share.

How you get paid: sponsors pay locally or through a remittance corridor. Verify AdSense eligibility inside your own account before assuming a payout route exists.

H Remote work

What it is: a job or a long contract with one employer, done from where you live. Local remote roles pay in dollars; foreign employers pay through a licensed corridor.

First month, honestly: hiring takes weeks and there is real competition. The upside is a stable monthly figure rather than a set of one-off jobs.

Skills needed: a specific employable skill, a reliable connection for calls, and a working CV.

Startup cost: $0.

Where the roles are: your country's business-process outsourcing sector employed roughly 25,000 people with about USD 50 million in revenue in 2025. Local companies, NGOs and remote-first firms also hire.

How you get paid: salary by bank transfer locally; foreign employers use your regulator-licensed remittance corridor.

1.3 How the paths compare

PATH	TIME TO A FIRST PAYMENT	PRICE CEILING	LAPTOP NEEDED?	REPEAT INCOME?
A Freelancing	Slow	Medium to high	Helps a lot	Yes, with repeat clients

PATH	TIME TO A FIRST PAYMENT	PRICE CEILING	LAPTOP NEEDED?	REPEAT INCOME?
B Local digital services	Fastest	Low to medium	No	Yes, if you ask
C AI-assisted services	Fast	Low to medium	No	Yes, on retainers
D Graphic design	Fast	Low to medium	No	Partly
E Social media management	Medium	Medium	No	Best of the eight
F Digital products	Slow	High over years	Helps	Yes, if it sells
G Content-based income	Very slow	High but unproven here	Helps	Unreliable
H Remote work	Slow	Highest and steadiest	Often yes	Yes, it is a job

This table is a judgement summary for planning, not a measurement. Your own starting skill changes it completely — a person who already edits video should not read the same row as somebody who has never opened an editor.

1.4 The eight-path trap

Here is how almost everybody fails. They read a list like the one above and feel that all eight are possible. So they make a Telegram channel for the content path, open a freelance profile, offer a friend a logo for free, and start a digital product — all in the same week.

Three weeks later, none of the four has thirty prospects, none has a written offer, none has a follow-up sent. The conclusion they draw is that online work does not pay where you live. The conclusion is wrong. **What failed was the divided attention, not the market.**

> **ONE PATH ONLY**
>
> For the next thirty days you will run exactly one path. Not two, not one plus a hobby project. If you find this difficult, notice that the difficulty is the point: choosing one is the skill this book is really teaching. Section 02 makes the choice for you with a scored worksheet, so you do not have to rely on willpower.

02

DECISION

The Opportunity Score

An eight-criteria worksheet that turns the choice of income path into arithmetic instead of mood, and closes the other seven paths on purpose.

01 Why a score and not a feeling

02 The eight criteria

03 Scoring the paths

04 Reading your totals

05 The spreading-yourself warning

You now have eight paths and one instruction: choose one. This section replaces the feeling of choosing with eight numbers you write down yourself.

The score is not a scientific instrument. It is a way to stop a decision from being made by whatever you watched most recently. Most readers find their top two are closer than expected, which is exactly when a tie-break rule earns its place.

2.1 The eight criteria

Score each path from 1 to 5 on each criterion. Five is the best possible. Be harsh; a generous score now costs you a month later.

EXPLAIN Eight criteria, chosen because each one is knowable before you start and each one changes whether a beginner finishes the month.

SHOW Two people score Freelancing. One has written professionally for a student magazine and scores 5 on existing skill. The other has never been paid to write and scores 2. Same path, different outcome, and the worksheet shows it before either of them spends a month finding out.

DO Draw the table below on paper or in a Google Sheet. Fill in a score for all eight paths on all eight criteria. Do not leave a cell blank to avoid a hard judgement.

CHECK Every cell has a number from 1 to 5, all eight paths have a total, and one path is circled with a line written under it: I am running this one for thirty days.

CRITERION	SCORE 5 IF	SCORE 1 IF
1. Speed to learn	You could deliver something acceptable this week.	It needs months of study before anyone would pay.
2. Phone-capable	The whole job can be done on the phone you own.	It genuinely needs a laptop you do not have.
3. Existing skill	You already do this for yourself, for study or for free.	You have never attempted it once.
4. Reachable buyers with no money	You can find and contact buyers for $0.	Buyers are only reachable through paid advertising.
5. Visible local demand	You can name ten businesses near you that clearly need it.	You cannot name three, anywhere.
6. Proof possible without clients	You can build a convincing sample this week with no client.	Nobody will believe you without a real past client.
7. Delivery speed	One job can be finished inside two days.	One job takes a month or more.
8. Price ceiling	A skilled person can eventually charge many thousands per job.	The market price is stuck at a few hundred dollars.

2.2 The worksheet

CRITERION	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
1. Speed to learn								
2. Phone-capable								

CRITERION	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
3. Existing skill								

CRITERION	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
4. Reachable buyers, no money								
5. Visible local demand								

CRITERION	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
6. Proof possible without clients								
7. Delivery speed								
8. Price ceiling								
Total out of 40								

A = Freelancing, B = Local digital services, C = AI-assisted services, D = Graphic design, E = Social media management, F = Digital products, G = Content-based income, H = Remote work.

2.3 Reading your totals

— **30 or more:** a strong match. Start today and do not look at the other paths again this month.

— **24 to 29:** workable. Look at which two criteria scored lowest; if either is phone-capable or speed to learn, fix that before Day 1.

— **18 to 23:** possible but slow. Choose it only if you have genuine enthusiasm, and expect a longer runway than thirty days.

— **Under 18:** do not start here. Take your second-highest total instead.

Tie-break rules, in order

1. Higher **price ceiling** wins, because it decides what your time is worth in month three.
2. If still tied, higher **speed to learn** wins, because a first payment in month one teaches more than a perfect plan.
3. If still tied, higher **visible local demand** wins, because local buyers can be met face to face.

> **WRITE THE DECISION DOWN**
>
> On one line, in a place you will see it: `I am running [path] for thirty days. I am not running the other seven.` That sentence is the deliverable of this section. If you cannot write it, you have not finished the section.

2.4 The spreading-yourself warning

There is one failure pattern that this worksheet exists to prevent, and it is worth naming plainly. It looks like this: path B is going well, so you add path D because a friend needs a poster, and then path F because you had an idea for a template. Within two weeks you have three half-built businesses and no completed work in any of them.

Three paths at 20% each is not three times the opportunity. It is zero completed paths. Sixty to ninety minutes a day split three ways is twenty to thirty minutes per path, which is less than the time it takes to send a proper round of outreach.

THE RULE FOR THE NEXT 30 DAYS

If an opportunity arrives on a path you did not choose, write it in a file called Later. Do not open the file until Day 31. Almost everything in it will look unimportant by then, and the few things that still matter will be worth doing properly.

03

SETUP

Zero-Budget Setup

Everything you build before you contact anyone: identity, email, a phone studio made from a window and a wall, Telegram used as a work tool, and the prospect tracker that runs the method.

01 Identity that looks professional

02 A studio made of light

03 Telegram as a work tool

04 The prospect tracker

05 The setup checklist

This section is the whole of Day 1 to Day 3 in the calendar. It costs nothing and it decides whether a stranger takes you seriously in the first four seconds.

Everything here has a phone path. Where a laptop makes a step faster, the laptop path is printed beside the phone path.

3.1 Identity that looks professional

You are not building a brand. You are removing reasons for a stranger to doubt you. Three things do most of that work: a real name, a clean email address, and a photo that looks like a person rather than a meme.

1. **Google account — phone path**
   Settings, then Accounts, then Add account. Use your real first and last name. If you already have an account with a nickname from 2016, create a second one for work rather than trying to rename the old one — old messages and group memberships carry the old identity with them.

2. **Google account — laptop path**
   Open a browser, go to the Google account sign-up page, and create the account in the same browser profile you will use for client work. Turn on two-step verification immediately; it is the single cheapest protection you own.

3. **A professional email address**
   Use the pattern `firstname.lastname@gmail.com` or `firstname.lastname.work@gmail.com`. Avoid numbers that look like a birth year, avoid nicknames, avoid anything a client would hesitate to read out loud to a colleague. If your name is taken, add a meaningful word, not a random digit string.

4. **Google Drive, in three folders**
   Create three folders: `Work Samples`, `Clients`, `Admin`. Inside Admin keep your tracker and your offer. Inside Clients make one folder per client, and inside that a folder called Delivered. This takes ten minutes and saves hours later.

> **TWO-STEP VERIFICATION**
>
> Turn it on for your Google account and your Telegram account today. The most common serious loss in this market is not a bad client; it is a stolen account. A stolen Telegram account is used to ask everybody in your contact list for money, and you cannot undo the damage to your name.

3.2 A studio made of light

Product and portrait photos decide whether a client believes your sample. You do not need equipment. You need light, a background and a steady hand.

- **Light:** stand your subject beside a window during daylight, with the window to the side rather than behind. Never shoot with a bright window behind the subject; the camera will darken the face or product to compensate.
- **Background:** a plain wall, a clean table, a sheet of paper. Remove the chair, the cable, the plastic bag.
- **Height:** hold the phone at the height of the object or at the eye level of the person. Shooting down at a plate makes the food look small.

— **Frames:** take three shots of everything — one wide, one close, one detail. Choose afterwards rather than reshooting on site.
— **Stability:** rest the phone on a stack of books or lean it against a wall. A propped phone beats a shaky hand every time.
— **Editing:** crop, straighten, and adjust brightness only. Over-saturated food photographs make a café look worse, not better.

LOW-BANDWIDTH PHOTO RULE

Send compressed images for approval and keep the full-quality file until the client accepts. Telegram's compressed photo option is usually enough for a yes or no, and it saves you most of the upload. Shoot at 720p for previews rather than 4K; a client approving a menu layout does not need a 4K file to make the decision.

3.3 Telegram as a work tool

Telegram is where a large share of local business conversations happen, and it moves files better than most alternatives on a weak connection. Treat your profile as a business card.

ELEMENT	WHAT TO SET
Username	A short, readable handle, ideally your name or your service plus your name. No numbers if you can avoid them.
Profile photo	A clear head-and-shoulders photo in daylight, or a clean typographic mark. Not a cartoon, not a car, not a flag.
Bio	One line: what you do, for whom, and how to reach you. Example: Menu design and product photos for cafes in Addis. DM or call 09xx xxx xxx.
Saved Messages	Your notebook. Draft messages, client details and file links go here so they survive a phone change.
Folders	Two folders: Clients and Prospects. Move conversations as they progress. This is your lightweight CRM.
Business hours	Decide them and hold them. Replying at 01:00 teaches clients that you are always available, and it burns you out inside a month.

ACCOUNT SECURITY

Scammers pose as Telegram security staff, ask for your password and your one-time code, take over the account, and then message your contacts asking for money. **No legitimate platform or bank ever asks you for a one-time code.** Never share it. Turn on two-step verification and set a recovery email you control.

3.4 The prospect tracker

One Google Sheet runs this entire method. Create a new sheet, name it Tracker, and rename the first tab `Prospects`. Put these fifteen headers in row 1, exactly in this order.

1. Business name
2. Category
1. Sub-city or town

1. Contact person
1. Phone
2. Telegram or Instagram handle
3. Map or listing link
4. What I noticed — one specific observation
1. Match to my offer — Yes, No or Maybe
2. First message sent — date
3. Follow-up 1 — date
4. Follow-up 2 — date
5. Final follow-up — date
6. Reply or status
7. Next action and date

Column 8 is the one that decides whether you get replies. If it says good business or nice cafe, it is useless. If it says menu photos from 2023, no prices, last post four months ago, it is the first line of a message that gets answered.

> **FREEZE ROW 1**
>
> On the phone app, tap the column header area and use the freeze option; on a laptop, View then Freeze then 1 row. You will scroll this sheet hundreds of times.

3.5 The rest of the kit

— **A free design tool** — a phone layout app or a browser-based design tool. You need it for menu layouts, posters and price lists. Free tiers on design tools usually limit exports, templates or resolution, so check the current limits before you build a client promise on one.

— **A free AI chat tool** — for drafting a first version of a caption, translating a paragraph, or checking whether your English reads clearly. You remain responsible for every word you send. Never hand a client raw machine output and never let a tool write a claim you cannot support.

— **A wallet you can actually receive into** — a mobile wallet, a mobile-money wallet, a bank wallet, a bank wallet, a mobile wallet or an ordinary bank account. Confirm your wallet level and daily limits before a client tries to pay you.

> **FREE PLANS CHANGE**
>
> Free plans change. Verify the current free limits before you build a workflow on a tool, and have a second tool in mind for anything a client depends on.

3.6 The setup checklist

Do not leave this section until every line below is ticked.

☐ Google account created or cleaned, with two-step verification on.

- [ ] Professional email address created and tested by sending yourself one message.

- [ ] Drive folders created: Work Samples, Clients, Admin.

- [ ] Telegram username, photo and one-line bio set.
- [ ] Two Telegram folders created: Clients and Prospects.
- [ ] Two-step verification on for Telegram.

- [ ] Three test photographs taken by a window, at object height, on a plain background.
- [ ] Tracker created with all fifteen headers, row 1 frozen.
- [ ] Design tool chosen and opened once.
- [ ] AI chat tool chosen and opened once.
- [ ] Wallet opened and daily limits checked in the app.

04

THE OFFER

Your Offer

Turning a skill into five sentences a business can say yes to, with two fully worked example offers, a worksheet and a copy-ready template.

01 The offer formula

02 Two worked examples

03 The offer worksheet

04 The copy-ready template

05 Testing the offer

An offer is not a description of you. It is a sentence about the client, and what changes for them if they pay you.

Most beginners write: I am a graphic designer, I can design anything you need, contact me. That message asks the client to do the thinking. A real offer does the thinking for them.

4.1 The offer formula

THE OFFER FORMULA — FIVE PARTS

`what you do + for whom + what they get + what it costs + how long it takes`

Five parts. If a part is missing, the client has to guess, and a guessing client does not reply.

PART	WEAK VERSION	STRONG VERSION
What you do	I do design.	I photograph food and design menu layouts.
For whom	For anyone.	For cafés and restaurants with fewer than twenty tables.
What they get	A nice design.	Twelve edited dish photos and a one-page menu with prices, sized for print and for Telegram.
What it costs	Depends.	$16 for the package. Half before, half on delivery.
How long it takes	Soon.	Photographs on one afternoon; finished files within four days.

4.2 Two worked offers

EXAMPLE SCENARIO — FICTIONAL Both businesses below are invented for teaching. They are not real companies and are not clients of anyone.

Worked offer 1 — the commercial district Beans Cafe

Example scenario — fictional. A small café in the commercial district with twelve tables, good food, and a menu photographed in 2023 with no prices printed.

THE OFFER

Selam. I photograph food and build menu layouts for small cafés in Addis. For the commercial district Beans Cafe I would shoot twelve dishes in one afternoon and deliver a one-page menu with prices, sized for print and for Telegram, plus the twelve edited photos. It costs $16, half before the shoot and half on delivery, and the finished files are with you within four days of the shoot.

Worked offer 2 — Lakeview Style House

Example scenario — fictional. A clothing shop in a regional city selling mostly through Telegram and Instagram, with poorly lit photos and prices only in the comments.

THE OFFER

Selam. I prepare product photos and price captions for clothing shops that sell on Telegram and Instagram. For Lakeview Style House I would photograph twenty items on a plain background, edit them for a phone screen, and write a price caption for each one in the local language and English. It costs $19, half before and half on delivery, and you get everything within five days.

WHY THESE WORK

Each one names a specific business type, a countable deliverable, a price, a payment split and a deadline. A client can say yes without asking a single clarifying question, which is the whole point. Nothing in either offer promises a result such as more customers or higher sales, because you cannot promise that.

4.3 The offer worksheet

Fill this in once, on paper or in your Admin folder. Do not move on until every line has an answer.

What I do — one sentence .....

Who it is for — be specific .....

What they get — countable items .....

What it costs — one number .....

Payment split .....

How long it takes .....

What is NOT included .....

The last line matters more than beginners expect. Writing what is not included prevents the most common dispute in freelance work: the client believed printing, hosting, translation or unlimited changes were part of the price.

4.4 Copy-ready offer template

COPY-READY: THE ONE-PARAGRAPH OFFER

Selam **[contact name]**. I **[what you do]** for **[type of business]** in **[area or town]**.

For **[business name]** I would **[countable deliverable 1]** and **[countable deliverable 2]**, delivered as **[file format]**.

It costs **[price]** USD — **[half]** before I start and the rest on delivery. You get everything within **[number]** days of **[trigger, for example the shoot or your approval]**.

Not included: **[printing, hosting, extra items, additional revisions]**.

If it helps, I can send two samples of similar work first. **[your name]**, **[phone]**.

4.5 Testing the offer before you send it

- [ ] A stranger can tell what you do in one reading, with no follow-up question.
- [ ] Every deliverable is countable — twelve photos, one page, twenty captions.
- [ ] There is exactly one price, not a range, not depends.

- [ ] The payment split is stated.

- [ ] The delivery time is stated, with the trigger it depends on.
- [ ] What is not included is stated.
- [ ] There is no promise of sales, followers, customers or income.
- [ ] You could deliver it alone, on your phone, inside the stated time.

If any line is unticked, fix it now. You will send this paragraph hundreds of times, and a weak offer does not improve with volume.

05

PROOF

Proof Without Clients

Building three labelled sample projects, a one-page work sample, before-and-after mockups and a how-I-work page, so a stranger can judge your work before hiring you.

01 Why proof comes before clients

02 Three sample projects

03 Labelling samples honestly

04 Before and after mockups

05 The how-I-work one-pager

You cannot get a client without proof and you cannot get proof without a client. This section breaks that circle without telling a single lie.

The method is simple: you make real work for imaginary briefs, and you label it clearly as sample work. Done properly, this is more convincing than a portfolio of unclear screenshots, because it shows that you can take a brief and finish it.

5.1 Why proof comes before clients

A business owner receiving your message is asking one question: has this person done this before, and will they finish? They cannot check your reputation, they do not know your name, and they have probably been let down by somebody who promised a poster and disappeared.

Proof answers the question in about four seconds, which is roughly how long they will look. Three finished, clearly labelled samples answer it better than a paragraph about your passion for design.

EXPLAIN A sample project is a complete piece of work you produced for a brief you wrote yourself. It is labelled a sample, it is dated, and it is finished to the standard you would deliver to a paying client.

SHOW You write this brief for yourself: a fictional café in the central district needs twelve dish photos and a one-page menu. You shoot a friend's cooking on a plain table by a window, build the menu at $16 worth of effort, and label every file Sample, created by [your name] for demonstration, September 2026. That is a real portfolio piece.

DO Write three one-line briefs now, matching the offer you wrote in section 04. Each brief names a business type, a countable deliverable and a deadline you will actually meet.

CHECK Three finished files exist in your Work Samples folder, each labelled as a sample, each viewable through a link that works on a phone with no Google account signed in.

5.2 Three sample projects

Three is the right number. One looks like a fluke, two look like a hobby, three look like a practice. Use three different businesses so the reader sees range without seeing confusion.

SAMPLE	TYPE OF BUSINESS	WHAT YOU PRODUCE	TIME
Sample 1	A café or restaurant	Twelve edited dish photos and one menu page with prices.	One afternoon plus one evening
Sample 2	A clothing or cosmetics shop	Twenty product photos on a plain background, plus the local language and English price captions.	Two evenings
Sample 3	A tour operator or guesthouse	A one-page listing sheet: five photos, a short description, contact block, price from.	One evening

Where do the subjects come from when you have no client? A friend's shop, your family's stall, your own belongings, a neighbour who is happy to be photographed for a favour. You are not selling anything at this stage. You are producing work.

LOW-BANDWIDTH DELIVERY OF SAMPLES

Build the samples on the phone. Export each one at screen resolution for the shared folder, and keep the full-resolution originals in a second folder. A prospect opening your link on a 3G connection should not have to download twelve 8 MB files. If you must upload originals, do it late at night when the network is quieter.

5.3 Labelling samples honestly

This is the part that separates a professional portfolio from a lie. Every sample file must carry a clear label. Put the label in the image itself, in the file name, and in the folder description.

COPY-READY: THE SAMPLE LABEL

On the image: a small line in the corner reading `SAMPLE — created by [your name] for demonstration. Not a client project.`

In the file name: `sample-cafe-menu-yourname-2026-09.jpg`

In the folder description: These are sample projects I produced for invented briefs to show how I work. They are not paid client work and the businesses shown are fictional. Real client work will be added here as it is completed and approved.

THREE THINGS YOU MUST NEVER DO

Never present a sample as client work. Not in the caption, not in the message, not by omission. If a client later discovers the truth, you lose the client and the reference.

Never copy somebody else's design and call it yours. Studying a design is fine. Passing it off as your own output is not, and it is usually obvious to anybody who works in the field.

Never photograph a business and imply they hired you. If you shot a friend's shop as practice, say practice in the label.

5.4 Before and after mockups

The single most persuasive sample is a before-and-after pair, because it shows the improvement a client is buying rather than the design you like.

1. **Capture the before**
   Find a real, publicly visible weakness — a menu photographed badly, a price list that is hard to read, a product photo with a cluttered background. Photograph the current state as it is. Do not mock anybody; photograph a real thing or recreate the problem with your own objects.

2. **Produce the after**
   Solve exactly one problem: legibility, lighting, or clarity of price. Do not redesign the whole brand. A single clean improvement is more believable than a fantasy rebrand.

1. **Put them side by side**
   Two images, one above the other, in one file. Add a two-line caption: what the problem was, what changed. Keep the sample label in the corner.

> **USE IT AS AN ILLUSTRATION, NOT AN ACCUSATION**
>
> When you send a before-and-after to a prospect, describe your own work, not their failure. Write: here is a before-and-after from a sample I made for a similar shop, so you can see the difference lighting makes. Never write: your photos are bad. Insulting the person who decides whether to pay you is a poor opening strategy.

5.5 The one-page work sample

A client who is interested wants one file they can forward to a partner or a manager. Build a single-page PDF that contains everything, because forwarding a folder of twelve images rarely happens.

— **Top:** your name, what you do, phone number and Telegram handle.

— **Middle:** three samples, one image each, with a one-line caption under each.

— **Bottom:** your offer in two sentences, the price for the standard package, and the line that this is sample work produced for demonstration.

Phone path: build it in a free design tool or Google Docs, export to PDF, and keep the file under a few megabytes so it sends easily on Telegram. Laptop path: Google Docs in a browser, then File, Download, PDF. Either way, name the file so it is obvious: `yourname-work-samples-2026.pdf`.

5.6 The how-I-work one-pager

This is a short document that removes the fear of hiring a stranger. It answers the four questions every client has and does not ask out loud.

COPY-READY: HOW I WORK

How I work — [your name], [what you do]

1. We agree the scope in writing. Before I start, you get one message listing exactly what I will deliver, the price, the payment split and the deadline. Nothing starts until you reply yes.

2. You pay half before I start. The second half is due on delivery. For work under [small amount] USD I can take the full amount on delivery instead.

3. One round of revisions is included. Send all your comments in one message within [three] days and I will make them. Further rounds are charged at [amount] USD.

4. You get the files in usable formats. [List the formats: print-ready PDF, PNG for social, original file if agreed.]

5. I reply during working hours. [08:00 to 18:00, Monday to Saturday]. If something will be late, you will hear it from me before the deadline, not after.

This page is not a legal contract and does not replace one. It is a clarity tool. Its purpose is that neither side is surprised later.

06

MONEY

Pricing in Dollars

How to set a first price with no experience, the ladder from a first cheap job to a normal price, three pricing models, and the exact words to use when somebody asks how much.

01 The first-price problem

02 The ladder

03 Three pricing models

04 Why monthly beats one-off

05 Raising your price, and the words for how much

Pricing is the part beginners get wrong in both directions: too cheap to be believable, or too expensive to be hired at all.

Every number in this section is an example for teaching, marked as such. Your market, your category and your skill level decide the real figures, and you will learn them faster by sending offers than by reading about them.

6.1 The first-price problem

You have no track record, no testimonials and no idea what the market pays. Three rules get you through the first month.

1. **Price the deliverable, not your time.** Twelve photos and a menu page is a thing with an end. Three hours of your afternoon is not something a café owner can evaluate.
2. **Do not price at zero.** Free work attracts clients who will never pay, and it tells the market your work has no value. If you want to build a portfolio, build a sample as in section 05.
3. **Give one number.** Depends is not a price. A range invites the client to negotiate downwards from the bottom.

> **EVERYTHING BELOW IS AN EXAMPLE**
>
> The ladders and figures in this section are **illustrative examples only**, printed to show the shape of a pricing decision. They are not market rates, they are not recommendations, and they are not promises of what any client will pay. Replace every number with what you learn from your own first ten conversations.

6.2 The ladder

Your price should climb as your proof climbs. Here is the shape of that climb, with example values.

STAGE	WHAT YOU HAVE	EXAMPLE PRICE	WHY
1. First job	Samples only, no testimonials	$3	Deliberately low, one time only, in exchange for a testimonial and permission to show the work.
2. Jobs two and three	One finished job, one testimonial	1,000 to $9	You now have evidence. The low price was a one-off, not your identity.
3. Normal price	Three finished jobs, three testimonials	2,000 to $19	This is your standard package price. Most work happens here.
4. Monthly client	A client who repeats	$16 per month	Predictable work, predictable money. See 6.4.
5. Specialist	A niche you are known for	4,000 to $35	Fewer competitors, buyers who compare you to nobody.

Example prices in USD for teaching only. They are not market data, not a guarantee, and not a recommendation. Adjust to what your own conversations reveal.

> **THE ONE-TIME DISCOUNT RULE**

If you discount, say out loud that it is a one-time introductory price in exchange for a testimonial and permission to use the work as a sample. Write it in the message. Otherwise the client will treat the low price as your real price forever, and the second job becomes an argument.

6.3 Three pricing models

Per job

What it is: one price for one deliverable.

Good for: first jobs, one-off requests, print work.

Watch out: scope creep. The client adds one more item each week and the price never moves.

Fix: write the count. Twelve photos, not a photo shoot.

Per package

What it is: a named bundle at a fixed price — for example the Cafe Starter: twelve photos, one menu page, three social posts.

Good for: selling quickly, because the client chooses rather than negotiates.

Watch out: a package can become a ceiling. Keep one line that says larger projects are quoted separately.

Fix: two packages, not five.

Per month

What it is: a fixed monthly fee for an agreed volume of work — eight posts, four photos, one report.

Good for: social media management, content, ongoing design.

Watch out: unpaid months. Agree the payment date, and stop work if it passes twice.

Fix: payment on the first working day of the month.

6.4 Why monthly beats one-off

A one-off job ends. A monthly client continues, and continuing income changes what you can plan. Three clients at $16 per month is $7,500 of expected income you can count before the month starts, against a set of one-off jobs you have to find again from zero every thirty days.

Monthly work is also cheaper to sell. Winning a new client costs you prospecting, messages and follow-ups. Extending an existing client costs one message asking whether they want the same again next month.

THE MONTHLY QUESTION

At the end of every successful job, ask one question: would you like me to keep this going monthly? Most beginners never ask it, which is why most beginners start every month from nothing.

6.5 Raising your price after three clients

After three completed jobs and three testimonials, raise your standard price for new clients. Do not raise it for the clients you already have without warning.

1. **Raise for new clients only**
   The next prospect who asks gets the new number. Your existing clients stay on the old price until their next cycle.

2. **Warn existing clients once**
   One month ahead: my price for this package becomes $19 from next month. I wanted to give you notice. Most clients accept it. The ones who do not were usually your most demanding clients anyway.

1. **Hold the new price**
   Do not negotiate yourself back down in the same conversation. If you lower it immediately, you have taught the client that your first number is fiction.

6.6 The exact words for how much

You will hear this question constantly. Prepare the answer, in writing, and reuse it. Do not improvise a price under pressure.

COPY-READY: THE PRICE REPLY

Thanks for asking. The `[package name]` is `[price]` USD. That covers `[countable deliverable]`, delivered within `[number]` days.

I take `[half]` before I start and the rest on delivery. If you want a smaller version to begin with, I can do `[smaller scope]` for `[lower price]` USD instead.

Which of the two would suit you better?

TWO SENTENCES THAT COST YOU MONEY

Whatever you think is fair is a sentence that hands pricing to the client. Is that okay? is a sentence that invites a no. State the price, state what it covers, then ask which option suits them — that last question keeps the conversation about scope rather than about whether you are worth anything.

07

PROSPECTING

Finding Prospects

Building a list of thirty named businesses with a specific, written observation about each one, using Google Maps and the directories that work where you live today.

01 The prospecting principle

02 Google Maps by area and category

03 Beyond your city

04 The other three surfaces

05 The tracker, with a worked example

A prospect is not a category. It is a named business, with a contact route and one specific thing you noticed about it.

By the end of this section you will have thirty of them. Thirty is the minimum useful number, because a first cold-message reply rate is low and you need enough conversations for the arithmetic to work.

7.1 The prospecting principle

Specificity beats volume, but you need volume before specificity pays. A list of thirty businesses with one real observation each will outperform a list of three hundred names copied from a directory with no notes.

The observation is the whole method. It is what turns a message that gets ignored into a message that gets a reply, because it proves you looked at their business rather than pasting the same paragraph to fifty people.

7.2 Google Maps by area and category

Google Maps is the primary discovery surface for local businesses where you live. Use it in two dimensions: choose an area, then choose a category inside that area.

1. **Pick one area, not the whole city**
   your city has ten sub-cities: the commercial district, the central district, the eastern district, the old town, the northern district, the western district, the outer district, the industrial district, the market district and the busiest district. Choose the one you can physically reach, because a client who can meet you in person closes faster and stays longer.

2. **Pick one category inside it**
   Cafés, restaurants, barber shops, beauty salons, gyms, boutiques, electronics shops, clinics, guesthouses, tour operators, print shops, bakeries. Choose the category your offer already names.

3. **Open the first twenty results, one at a time**
   For each business, look at three things: the photos, whether prices appear anywhere, and whether there is a website or social link. Note the last time they posted, if the listing links to a page.

4. **Write one specific observation per business**
   Examples of usable observations: menu photos from 2023; no prices anywhere; last post four months ago; photos taken at night under yellow light; listing has no description; two reviews mention slow replies. These are all visible from outside and all fixable by the work you sell.

A NOTE ON GOOGLE BUSINESS PROFILE

your country appears on the official list of supported countries for Google Business Profile, which means a local listing is a legitimate service you can offer. Verify the current terms in your own account before promising a client a specific outcome, and never promise a ranking position.

7.3 Beyond your city

This method is not an Addis method. It is a Google Maps method, and it works anywhere the map has coverage. The cities below all have enough listed businesses to build a list of thirty inside a week.

TOWN OR CITY	WHERE TO START	CATEGORIES WORTH CHECKING FIRST
a regional city	Map search around the lakefront and the main roundabout areas.	Guesthouses, tour operators, cafés.

TOWN OR CITY	WHERE TO START	CATEGORIES WORTH CHECKING FIRST
a regional city	Map search along the lakeside and the market district.	Fish restaurants, hotels, clothing shops.

TOWN OR CITY	WHERE TO START	CATEGORIES WORTH CHECKING FIRST
a regional city	Map search in the city centre.	Clinics, retail shops, restaurants.
a regional city	Map search around the main market and station area.	Traders, guesthouses, electronics shops.

TOWN OR CITY	WHERE TO START	CATEGORIES WORTH CHECKING FIRST
a regional city	Map search along the main highway corridor.	Fuel-adjacent businesses, restaurants, hotels.
a regional city	Map search around the university area and the centre.	Cafés, stationery and print shops, hostels.
a regional city	Map search near the castle area and the bus station.	Tour operators, hotels, restaurants.

Other towns with a workable business base include a smaller town, a smaller town, a smaller town, a smaller town, a smaller town and Debre Birhan. The rule is the same everywhere: one area, one category, twenty listings, one observation each.

> **THE REGIONAL ADVANTAGE**
>
> Competition for digital services is thinnest outside Addis. A café in a regional city or a guesthouse in a regional city may never have been contacted by anybody offering menu photography or page management. The trade-off is that budgets are often smaller, so your package should be sized to the local market rather than copied from Addis.

7.4 The other three surfaces

— **a local classifieds site** — live classifieds with USD prices, covering Addis sub-cities and a Services section. Useful for finding businesses that already sell online and therefore already care about their listings. Look at the quality of the photos and the completeness of the descriptions; both are things you can improve for a fee.

— **an online business directory** — around thirty categories with company counts and a fourteen-city filter, including Import and Export, Professional Services, Factories, Construction, and Restaurants and Cafes. Good for building a category list fast when you already know which type of business you serve.

— **an online business directory** — a large business directory with more than ten thousand companies listed, and a free add-your-business option. Treat it as a source of names and contact details, then do the real observation work on the map and on their own pages.

— **Chamber and association lists** — the local Chamber of Commerce and Sectoral Associations links around a dozen chambers and several associations with phone numbers. This is better for reaching a group than for building an individual prospect list.

DO NOT BUILD A MARKETPLACE

Every few months somebody decides the real opportunity is starting an online marketplace. Research on local e-commerce platforms found that over half earn less than ten thousand US dollars a year. That is not the business to start with no capital and no team. Sell a service first.

7.5 The tracker, with a worked example

Use the fifteen columns from section 03. Below is what five filled rows look like. Every business here is invented.

BUSINESS	CATEGORY	AREA	WHAT I NOTICED	MATCH	FIRST MESSAGE	NEXT ACTION
City Fitness Center FICTIONAL	Gym	the commercial district	Photos are empty-room shots; no prices; last post five months ago	Yes	Day 15	Follow-up 1 on Day 18
Eastside Motors FICTIONAL	Auto service	the industrial district	Listing has no description and only two photos, both blurred	Maybe	Day 15	Call the listed number on Day 16
Highland Tour Link FICTIONAL	Tour operator	a regional city	Sells tours but the listing has no prices and no itinerary page	Yes	Day 16	Follow-up 1 on Day 19
Lakeview Style House FICTIONAL	Clothing	a regional city	Product photos taken under yellow light; prices only in comments	Yes	Day 16	Send the before-and-after sample
the commercial district Beans Cafe FICTIONAL	Café	the commercial district	Menu photos from 2023 and no prices printed	Yes	Day 17	Walk in with the one-page sample

All five businesses are **Example scenario — fictional** and are not real companies.

The rules for building the list of 30

- [ ] One area, one category to start. Do not mix five categories in week one.
- [ ] Thirty rows, each with a named business and a real contact route.
- [ ] Every row has a specific observation. Good photos is not an observation.
- [ ] At least twenty rows marked Yes or Maybe on match.
- [ ] Phone numbers in a consistent format so you can dial them without thinking.
- [ ] The list saved in Google Sheets, not only in your head or in a notebook.
- [ ] Nothing in the list copied from a competitor or bought from a seller.

08

OUTREACH

Outreach That Gets Replies

The personalised first line, daily message volume, the three-follow-up rule, and eight copy-ready scripts covering first contact, follow-ups, price questions, refusals and referrals.

01 The first line decides everything

02 How many, and how often

03 The three-follow-up rule

04 When nobody replies

05 Eight copy-ready scripts

This is the section that decides whether the month produces money. Everything before it was preparation.

Outreach is a numbers game with a quality floor. The quality floor is one personalised line per message. The numbers are five to ten messages a day, every working day.

8.1 The first line decides everything

A business owner reads the first line and decides whether to read the second. Write that line about them, not about you.

DO NOT WRITE	WRITE
Hello, I am a graphic designer offering affordable services.	Selam, I saw your menu photos are from 2023 and there are no prices on the listing.
I can help your business grow with digital marketing.	Your last three posts are product photos taken under yellow light, which makes the colours hard to judge.
We offer quality services at competitive prices.	Your listing has no description and only two photos, so a customer searching gym in the commercial district sees less than your competitors.

The pattern is the same each time: name the specific thing you saw, then stop. The offer comes second. If the first line is about them, the second line gets read.

EXPLAIN Personalisation is one sentence, not a paragraph. It proves you looked. More than one sentence makes the message feel like work to read.

SHOW Two cafés in the commercial district get two different first lines: one about missing prices, one about evening photographs taken under yellow light. The rest of the message is identical because the offer is identical.

DO Send five messages today. Not tomorrow. Today. Use the scripts in 8.5 and change only the first line and the name.

CHECK Five sent messages visible in Telegram or WhatsApp, and five rows in the tracker with today's date in the first-message column.

8.2 How many, and how often

5-10	3	30	6
NEW MESSAGES A DAY	FOLLOW-UPS PER PROSPECT, MAXIMUM	NAMES ON YOUR FIRST LIST	WORKING DAYS A WEEK

Five to ten a day is enough to produce a first client within a month for most people who keep going, and small enough that you can personalise each message properly. Thirty messages in one afternoon, all with the same opening line, will underperform five good ones a day.

Send during business hours. A message that arrives at 22:00 gets buried by morning, and it signals that you work at odd hours, which clients learn to exploit.

8.3 The three-follow-up rule

Most replies come from follow-ups, not from first messages. Most beginners send one message and stop, then conclude the market is dead.

1. **Message — Day 0**
   The personalised first message with the offer.
2. **Follow-up 1 — Day 3**
   One short line, adding something new: a sample image, a specific observation, or a question. Repeating the first message is not a follow-up.
3. **Follow-up 2 — Day 8**
   A different angle. Offer the smaller version of the package, or ask whether the timing is wrong.
4. **Final follow-up — Day 15**
   Close the loop politely and leave the door open. Then mark the row Closed and stop. Do not send a fifth.

WHY THREE IS THE NUMBER

Three follow-ups over two weeks catches the owner who was travelling, the one who was busy, and the one who needed to see your work twice before deciding. A fourth message starts to cost you your reputation in a market where everybody talks to everybody.

8.4 When nobody replies

Silence is the normal state of outreach, not evidence that you are failing. Work through this list in order before you change anything.

1. **Volume.** Have you actually sent thirty messages, or eight? Eight is not a result. Thirty is a small result.
2. **First line.** Is it about them, and is it specific? Reread your last ten. If three of them could be sent to any business, they were not personalised.
3. **Channel.** Telegram may be wrong for this category. Try a phone call, a walk-in, or an Instagram DM. Some owners only answer the phone.
4. **Category.** Some categories have no budget right now. If twenty cafés all ignore you, try guesthouses or clinics before concluding anything about the market.
5. **Ask.** Is there a clear, small next step? An offer that ends with let me know if you are interested gives nobody anything to do. An offer that ends with shall I send the sample? gets an answer.

DO NOT CHANGE THE OFFER EVERY THREE DAYS

The most common self-sabotage is rewriting the offer after every four ignored messages. You cannot learn anything from four. Give one offer thirty messages and one round of follow-ups before you judge it.

8.5 Eight copy-ready scripts

Replace every bracketed part. Keep the length; shortening a script to two lines removes the reason to reply, and lengthening it removes the chance.

SCRIPT 1 — FIRST OUTREACH, LOCAL BUSINESS

Selam **[name]**, I saw **[specific observation, for example your menu photos are from 2023 and there are no prices on the listing]**.

I **[what you do]** for **[business type]** in **[area]**. For **[business name]** I would **[countable deliverable]** for **[price]** USD, finished within **[number]** days.

I have three samples from similar work. Shall I send them here? **[your name]**

SCRIPT 2 — FIRST OUTREACH, ONLINE CLIENT

Hello **[name]**, I read your **[post, listing or profile]** about **[specific detail]** and noticed **[specific observation]**.

I **[what you do]**. I can **[countable deliverable]** for **[price]** USD, delivered in **[number]** days, with one round of revisions included.

I can send two samples first if that helps. Would you like the smaller version at **[lower price]** USD to start?

SCRIPT 3 — FOLLOW-UP 1 (DAY 3)

Selam **[name]**, following up briefly. Here is a before-and-after from a sample I made for a similar **[business type]**, so you can see what changes.

If it is useful, I can do the same for **[business name]** in **[number]** days. If the timing is wrong, tell me and I will not bother you again.

SCRIPT 4 — FOLLOW-UP 2 (DAY 8)

Selam **[name]**, one more thought. If the full package is more than you want to spend right now, I can start with **[smaller scope]** for **[lower price]** USD instead.

Same quality, smaller first step. Would that be a better place to start?

SCRIPT 5 — FINAL FOLLOW-UP (DAY 15)

Selam **[name]**, I will stop following up after this message. If **[deliverable]** becomes useful later, my number is **[phone]** and the samples stay here: **[link]**.

Thank you for your time, and good luck with **[something specific and genuine about their business]**.

SCRIPT 6 — PRICE REPLY

Thanks for asking. The [package] is [price] USD. It includes [countable deliverable], one round of revisions, and delivery in [number] days.

Payment is [half] before I start and the rest on delivery. I can also do [smaller scope] for [lower price] USD if you would rather start smaller. Which suits you better?

SCRIPT 7 — NOT NOW REPLY

Understood, and thank you for telling me rather than leaving it. I will check back in [month] unless you would rather I did not.

In the meantime, if [one small quick thing] would help, I can do that on its own for [small price] USD. Either way, good luck with the [season or event].

SCRIPT 8 — REFERRAL ASK

Thank you for the work — the [deliverable] is finished and the files are in the folder I sent.

One small request: do you know one other [business type] owner who might need the same? If you introduce us, I will give you [a discount on your next job or a small thank-you]. No pressure either way.

8.6 Two replies you will have to handle

We already have someone

Do not argue and do not criticise the other person. Reply: that makes sense. If it ever changes, or if you need a second pair of hands for a busy period, my samples are here. Then ask one useful question: is there anything they do not cover, such as print files or the local language captions?

Many of these prospects come back within six months. The one who behaved professionally is the one they remember.

Send it and we will see

This is a request for free work. Reply: happy to. The first [small sample] is free so you can judge the quality; the full set is [price] USD with [half] before I start.

Give a small, real sample of actual work — one edited photo, one caption. Never hand over the whole deliverable before payment.

09

DELIVERY AND PAYMENT

Delivery and Getting Paid

The onboarding message, scope note, milestones, delivery message, revision policy and invoice wording — plus exactly how money reaches an unlicensed individual where you live, and what does not work.

01 The four questions that settle it in twenty minutes

02 Local clients versus international clients

03 The legitimate routes, in order

04 What never to do

05 Tax and registration, honestly

A client who has said yes is not yet a client who has paid. This section covers the short sequence that turns agreement into money in your wallet without damaging the relationship.

The payment part is the most your country-specific material in the book, and it is the part where guessing costs people real money. Read 9.5 carefully.

How You Get Paid, and What to Do First

This is the chapter that decides whether the rest of the book turns into money. It is also the chapter most online advice gets wrong, because most online advice assumes you live in a country with a full set of payment rails. If you do, the short version is at the end of this section. If you do not, the rest of this section is for you.

> **THE ONE RULE THAT PREVENTS ALMOST EVERY PROBLEM**
>
> **Agree the payment route with the client before you agree the price.** Not after the work is done, not in the invoice, not when they ask for your bank details. Before.
>
> A client who cannot pay you the way you need is not a client. They are a conversation. Finding that out on delivery day is the most expensive lesson in this book, and it is entirely avoidable with one question asked early.

How money actually crosses a border

When a client in another country pays you, the money does not travel directly. It moves through a chain, and every link in that chain is a place where it can stop. Knowing the chain tells you which question to ask.

1. **The client pays something**
   A card, a PayPal balance, a bank transfer, a mobile wallet, a local payment method. What they can use depends on *their* country, not yours.

2. **A processor authorises it**
   Stripe, PayPal, Adyen, a regional gateway. This is where most cross-border problems originate, because processors operate country by country.

3. **A platform holds it**
   If you sell through a marketplace or course platform, they hold the money and pay you later, on their schedule, at their minimum.

4. **It is paid out to you**
   A bank deposit in your local currency, a PayPal transfer, or a wallet credit. **This is the link that fails most often**, and it is the one nobody checks before they start.

EXPLAIN Buyer-side and seller-side are independent. What your client can use to pay has nothing to do with what you can receive. A platform can be perfectly good for your buyers and completely useless for paying you.

SHOW *Example — fictional.* A writer in Nairobi sells a $25 template pack. Buyers pay by card without difficulty. The platform's payout page then shows one option: PayPal. The writer's PayPal account can send but cannot receive. Fourteen sales, $350, stuck behind a payout route that was never tested.

DO Before you build anything, open the payout settings of every platform you are considering and write down, in one sentence, exactly how money would reach your bank account.

CHECK Can you name the rail, the currency, the minimum payout and the delay? If any of those four is a guess, you have not finished checking.

The four questions that settle it in twenty minutes

Do this once per platform. It takes about twenty minutes and it prevents weeks of wasted work.

QUESTION	WHERE TO LOOK	WHAT A USABLE ANSWER LOOKS LIKE
1. Does this platform pay out to my country?	The platform's own payout-settings page or help article — never a blog post, never a YouTube video	Your country named on the platform's own list, with the payout currency
2. Through which rail?	The same page	A named method: local bank deposit, PayPal, Payoneer, wallet. "Contact support" is not an answer
3. What is the minimum and the delay?	The payout help article	A number and a schedule, so you can plan cash flow
4. What does it cost in total?	The pricing page *and* the fees help article — they often disagree	Platform fee plus processing fee, added together, expressed as a percentage of a typical sale

TWO RULES THAT WILL SAVE YOU MONEY

Read the payout page, not the signup page. Almost every platform lets you sign up from almost anywhere. That tells you nothing. The gate is payout.

Check whether two platforms share a rail. If two services both pay through the same underlying processor, they are not backups of each other. When that one rail has a problem, both stop at once. Verify the underlying rail, not just the brand on the front.

Local clients versus international clients

These are two different problems and they need two different answers. Do not let one delay the other.

	LOCAL CLIENTS	INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS
What works	Bank transfer, mobile wallet, cash, a local card gateway. Almost always available to an individual with no registered business.	A licensed remittance corridor, a platform that pays out to your country, or an employer's own payroll route.
Speed	Same day, often same hour	Days to weeks, depending on the platform's payout schedule
What can block it	Nothing much, if you have an account in your own name	Country eligibility, missing documents, a rail that does not reach you
Best first move	Start here. Local clients pay for your proof.	Test the payout route with a small real payment before you promise anything

THE TEST PAYMENT

Before you quote a single international client, run one small real transaction end to end: sell something cheap — a $5 template, a $10 review, a single small job — and take it all the way to money in your account.

This costs you one afternoon and one small fee. It converts every assumption in this chapter into a fact, and it is the single most useful hour in this entire book.

What to say to a client about payment

Clients are not suspicious of payment questions. They are suspicious of vague ones. Say the route plainly, in the first conversation, in writing.

COPY-READY: THE PAYMENT-ROUTING MESSAGE

Before we start, one practical thing so neither of us has a surprise at the end.

I am paid by **[route: bank transfer / a named platform / a licensed transfer service]**. The money arrives in **[currency]**, and I can start work as soon as the first payment shows on my side.

If you would rather use a different method, tell me now and I will check whether it works — I would rather spend five minutes on this today than a week on it later.

For **[amount]** the split is **[50]** % to start and **[50]** % on delivery.

COPY-READY: WHEN A PAYMENT IS LATE

Hello **[name]** — checking in on the **[amount]** for **[work]**, which I sent on **[date]**. It has not shown on my side yet.

Could you confirm the date it was sent and the reference number? If it has not gone out yet, no problem — just let me know when it will, and I will plan around that.

Pricing when the route costs money

Cross-border routes cost the sender or the receiver money. Decide who absorbs it before you quote, and put it in the price rather than discovering it later.

WORKED EXAMPLE — TARGET ARITHMETIC, NOT A FORECAST

```
Your price for the work: $100
Transfer or platform cost, if you absorb it: $5–$15
What actually reaches you: $85–$95
```

Two ways to handle it: quote a price that already includes the cost, or state plainly that transfer fees are the sender's. What you must not do is quote $100 and then argue about $12 after delivery.

NEVER DO THESE THINGS, WHATEVER ANYONE TELLS YOU

— **Never enter a false country, name or address** on a payment platform. It breaches the provider's terms, it usually fails identity verification anyway, and the consequence is a frozen balance and a closed account — with your customers refunded and your earnings gone.

— **Never use a relative's or friend's account abroad** to receive money that is yours. It is the same misrepresentation with extra steps, and it puts their account at risk too.

— **Never use a VPN to open a financial account** in a country you do not live in.

— **Never buy or rent a verified account.** The seller keeps access to it.

— **Never accept payment in a form your country restricts.** Several countries prohibit or restrict virtual-asset transactions; check your own before you accept anything unusual.

The published terms are unambiguous about this. Most platforms require you not to "create an account using a false identity or information, or on behalf of someone other than yourself", and prohibit misrepresenting your "identity, location or credentials". The stated remedy is suspension or termination, and where an underlying processor makes the final call it is often not appealable.

The legitimate routes, in the order worth trying

#	ROUTE	WHO IT SUITS	WHAT TO VERIFY FIRST
1	A platform that publishes your country on its own payout list, paying into a local bank account in local currency	Anyone selling digital products or courses	That the payout page offers *bank deposit*, not "PayPal only", for your country
2	A licensed money-transfer service (Western Union, MoneyGram, Remitly, WorldRemit and similar) for a one-off client payment	Freelancers and service sellers with a single client	That the receiving country and currency appear on the provider's own corridor list
3	An employer's own payroll or contractor route	Remote employees and long-term contractors	That the employer has paid a contractor in your country before — ask them directly
4	Registering as an exporter of services and receiving into a foreign-currency account	Anyone earning regularly from abroad	Your own country's rules. In several countries this unlocks full retention of foreign-currency earnings and an international card — ask a local accountant, do not guess
5	Trading through a properly registered company in the country where the payout account sits	Established sellers doing meaningful volume	Real incorporation, a real bank account there, real accounting, and any home-country approval required. Legitimate, but slow and expensive — not a shortcut

IF YOU ALREADY HAVE FULL PAYMENT RAILS

Then most of this chapter is not your constraint, and your fastest route is whatever your clients already use: Stripe, PayPal, a card gateway. Skim the four verification questions above anyway — the platform fee difference between two similar services is often several percentage points, and on a hundred sales a year that is real money.

Tax and registration, stated honestly

THIS IS NOT TAX ADVICE, AND THE RULES ARE LOCAL

Almost every country requires you to declare income you earn, and most require some form of tax registration once you are trading. What that means in practice — a tax number, a business registration, a turnover-tax threshold, a VAT threshold — differs enormously from country to country, and the thresholds change.

What to do: find your national tax authority's own website, look for the page on registering as a sole trader or self-employed person, and read the current threshold. If your earnings are small, you may be below every threshold. If they are not, register. A local accountant charges very little for one hour of advice, and that hour is worth more than any general guidance in a book written for the whole world.

Keep a simple record from your first sale: date, client, amount, currency, what it was for, and the fee deducted. That one sheet makes tax time trivial and makes you look professional if anyone ever asks.

IF YOU SELL THROUGH A MARKETPLACE, READ THIS

Large platforms are often the *merchant of record*, meaning they handle sales tax and VAT for the buyer and remit it themselves. That does not remove your obligation to declare the income you receive. It changes what you have to collect, not whether you have to report.

Some platforms also require a tax form before they will pay you at all — a W-9 if you are in the United States, a W-8 series form if you are not, or a local equivalent. If a form is required and not submitted, payouts are usually paused. Complete it early rather than after your first sale.

10

IMPLEMENTATION

The 30-Day Calendar

A day-by-day plan for thirty days at 60 to 90 minutes a day, with objectives, tasks, examples, outputs and checks, plus catch-up days and a rule for falling behind.

01 How the month is shaped

02 Days 1 to 7 — choose and set up

03 Days 8 to 14 — proof and prospects

04 Days 15 to 22 — outreach and follow-up

05 Days 23 to 30 — deliver, get paid, decide

06 If you fall behind

This is the engine of the book. Thirty days, 60 to 90 minutes a day, one path, one objective per day.

Each day has the same five parts: the objective, the task, a concrete example, the output you must produce, and the check that tells you it is finished. If a day produces nothing you can point to, it did not happen.

10.1 How the month is shaped

7	7	8	8
DAYS TO CHOOSE AND SET UP	DAYS TO BUILD PROOF AND PROSPECTS	DAYS OF OUTREACH AND FOLLOW-UP	DAYS TO DELIVER, GET PAID, DECIDE

The shape matters. Nothing in the first two weeks earns money, and that is deliberate: you cannot sell to strangers with no offer and no proof. Outreach starts on Day 15 and continues every working day until Day 30, even while you are delivering work, because a month with no prospecting ends with no pipeline.

DAYS 7, 14, 21 AND 28 ARE CATCH-UP DAYS

They exist because life happens: exams, power cuts, a slow network, a family obligation. A catch-up day is not a rest day unless you are genuinely ahead. Use it to finish whatever is unfinished, then look at the next week.

IF YOU FALL BEHIND — THE RULE

Never double up to catch a missed day. Doing two days in one evening produces two half-finished days. Instead: **protect the outreach block and sacrifice the extras.** If you are more than three days behind by Day 14, drop the third sample project and keep Days 13 to 22 exactly on schedule. The samples are preparation; the messages are the business. A reader who sends thirty messages with two samples will beat a reader with three samples and no messages every time.

10.2 Days 1 to 7 — choose and set up

DAY 01 Choose your one path

OBJECTIVE Close seven options and open one.

TASK Read section 01. Draw the eight-criteria worksheet from section 02 and score all eight paths from 1 to 5 on every criterion.

EXAMPLE Local digital services scores 31, freelancing 26, content-based income 17. You run local digital services.

OUTPUT A completed worksheet with one path circled and the sentence written: I am running this one for thirty days.

CHECK

- [ ] All 64 cells have a number.
- [ ] One path is circled and the other seven are closed on purpose.

DAY 02 Identity and storage

OBJECTIVE A stranger can find your name, email and files without confusion.

TASK Create or clean your Google account. Claim a professional email address. Create the three Drive folders: Work Samples, Clients, Admin. Turn on two-step verification.

EXAMPLE `hanna.tesfaye.work@gmail.com` instead of `honeygirl2004@gmail.com`.

OUTPUT A working email address and three empty Drive folders.

CHECK

- [ ] You sent yourself a test email and received it.
- [ ] Two-step verification is on.

DAY 03 Telegram as a work tool

OBJECTIVE Your Telegram profile looks like a business card instead of a personal chat account.

TASK Set a readable username, a clear profile photo, and a one-line bio saying what you do and for whom. Create two folders: Clients and Prospects. Turn on two-step verification.

EXAMPLE Bio: Menu design and product photos for cafes in Addis. DM or call 09xx xxx xxx.

OUTPUT A finished profile and two working folders.

CHECK

- [ ] Ask one friend what you do, based only on your profile.
- [ ] Two-step verification is on and your recovery email is one you control.

DAY 04 Build the studio

OBJECTIVE Produce photographs that look deliberate rather than accidental.

TASK Find a window and a plain wall. Photograph three objects at their own height with the window to the side. Take one wide, one close and one detail shot of each.

EXAMPLE A plate of food on a clean table beside a window, phone propped on two books, shot at plate height.

OUTPUT Nine photographs saved in Work Samples.

CHECK

- [ ] No shot has a bright window behind the subject.
- [ ] No shot has a cable, bag or chair in the frame.

DAY 05 Build the tracker and open the wallet

OBJECTIVE	Your working system exists before it has data in it.
TASK	Create the Google Sheet with the fifteen headers from section 03. Freeze row 1. Open your wallet app, find your daily limits, and switch on two-factor authentication.
EXAMPLE	Row 1 ends with: Reply or status, Next action and date.
OUTPUT	A tracker with fifteen headers and a written note of your wallet limits.
CHECK	☐ Row 1 is frozen and readable on the phone. ☐ You can state your daily person-to-person transfer limit without looking it up.

DAY 06 Write the offer

OBJECTIVE	Five sentences a business owner can say yes to.
TASK	Fill the offer worksheet in section 04. Write the paragraph using the copy-ready template. State what is not included.
EXAMPLE	Twelve edited dish photos and a one-page menu with prices for $16, half before and half on delivery, finished within four days of the shoot.
OUTPUT	One written offer saved in your Admin folder.
CHECK	☐ One price, one deadline, countable deliverables. ☐ Read it aloud. If you stumble, it is too long.

DAY 07 Catch-up and confirm

OBJECTIVE	Week one ends complete, not approximately complete.
TASK	Work through the section 03 checklist and tick every line. Finish anything outstanding. Then read section 05 once, without doing it.
EXAMPLE	You have the tracker but no wallet limits noted, so today you open the app and write them down.
OUTPUT	All eleven setup ticks complete.
CHECK	☐ Nothing from section 03 is unfinished. ☐ You know what you are producing next week.

10.3 Days 8 to 14 — proof, portfolio and prospects

DAY 08 Write three briefs, shoot sample one

OBJECTIVE	Work to a brief you wrote yourself, exactly as if a client wrote it.
TASK	Write three one-line briefs for three different business types. Shoot the photographs for sample one.
EXAMPLE	Brief: a cafe in the central district needs twelve dish photos and a one-page menu with prices.
OUTPUT	Three briefs written, twelve photographs taken.
CHECK	☐ Each brief names a business type, a count and a deadline. ☐ Twelve usable frames exist.

DAY 09 Finish and label sample one

OBJECTIVE	One complete, honestly labelled portfolio piece.
TASK	Edit the twelve photos, build the menu page, and add the sample label to every file. Put them in Work Samples with view sharing on.
EXAMPLE	Corner label: Sample — created by [your name] for demonstration. Not a client project.
OUTPUT	One labelled sample project and a working share link.
CHECK	☐ The link opens on a phone with no Google account signed in. ☐ No file implies a real client.

DAY 10 Sample two

OBJECTIVE	A second sample in a different category, so your range is visible.
TASK	Photograph twenty items on a plain background and write one price caption for each, in the local language and English.
EXAMPLE	Twenty clothing items on a white sheet by a window, each with a caption giving size and price.
OUTPUT	Twenty labelled product images and twenty captions.
CHECK	☐ Every image is labelled as a sample. ☐ Captions use real grammar, not machine output pasted straight in.

DAY 11 Sample three and the one-page PDF

OBJECTIVE	A third sample plus one file a client can forward.
TASK	Build a one-page listing sheet for a guesthouse or tour operator. Then assemble the one-page work sample PDF containing three images, your contact block and your offer in two sentences.
EXAMPLE	Five photos, a short description, a price-from line and a contact block, labelled as a sample.
OUTPUT	Three completed samples and one PDF under a few megabytes.
CHECK	☐ The PDF opens on a phone and scrolls cleanly. ☐ Your phone number appears once, clearly.

DAY 12 Before and after, and how I work

OBJECTIVE	Show the improvement a client is buying, and remove the fear of hiring you.
TASK	Make one before-and-after pair solving a single problem. Write the how-I-work one-pager from section 05.
EXAMPLE	A dim, cluttered product photo above a bright, plain-background version of the same item.
OUTPUT	One before-and-after image and one how-I-work document.
CHECK	☐ The caption describes your work, never criticises a named business. ☐ The policy states one revision round and the payment split.

DAY 13 Prospect list, first fifteen

OBJECTIVE	Fifteen named businesses, each with one specific observation.
TASK	Open Google Maps. Choose one district or town and one category. Open twenty listings and write fifteen into the tracker with an observation each.
EXAMPLE	the commercial district, gyms: photos are empty-room shots, no prices, last post five months ago.
OUTPUT	Fifteen completed rows in the tracker.
CHECK	☐ Every row has a contact route. ☐ No two observations are identical.

DAY 14 Catch-up and the second fifteen

OBJECTIVE	Thirty prospects on the list before you send anything.
TASK	Finish anything outstanding from Days 8 to 13, then add fifteen more businesses. If you are behind, drop sample three and keep the list on schedule.
EXAMPLE	Second area or a second category inside the same town, so you are not competing with yourself for the same buyers.
OUTPUT	Thirty rows, at least twenty marked Yes or Maybe.
CHECK	☐ Thirty rows exist. ☐ At least three finished samples or the one-page PDF exist.

10.4 Days 15 to 22 — outreach and follow-up

DAY 15 First five messages

OBJECTIVE	Stop preparing and start contacting.
TASK	Send five messages using script 1 or script 2, each with a personalised first line. Record the date in column 10 of the tracker.
EXAMPLE	Selam, I saw your menu photos are from 2023 and there are no prices on the listing.
OUTPUT	Five sent messages and five dated rows.
CHECK	☐ Five messages are visible in your sent history. ☐ Every one has a first line that could not be sent to anybody else.

DAY 16 Five more, and two on foot

OBJECTIVE	Add a channel that does not depend on a connection.
TASK	Send five more messages, then visit two businesses on your list in person with the one-page sample printed or on your phone.
EXAMPLE	Walk into a cafe at 15:00, ask for the owner by name, and show the before-and-after pair on your phone.
OUTPUT	Five messages sent and two in-person conversations, all recorded.
CHECK	☐ You asked for a name and a phone number in both visits. ☐ Both visits are in the tracker with a next action.

DAY 17 Five more, and prepare the price reply

OBJECTIVE	Volume up, and no hesitation when somebody asks how much.
TASK	Send five more messages. Copy script 6 into your Saved Messages so the price reply is one tap away.
EXAMPLE	The package is $16, half before and half on delivery, finished in four days. Which version suits you better?
OUTPUT	Fifteen total messages sent and a saved price reply.
CHECK	☐ Fifteen rows have a first-message date. ☐ You can send a price without rewriting it.

DAY 18 Follow-up 1 and five new

OBJECTIVE	Most replies come from follow-ups. Send them.
TASK	Send follow-up 1 (script 3) to the Day 15 batch, each with a sample image. Then send five new first messages.
EXAMPLE	Here is a before-and-after from a sample I made for a similar cafe, so you can see what changes.
OUTPUT	Five follow-ups sent and twenty messages total.
CHECK	☐ Each follow-up adds something new rather than repeating the first message. ☐ Column 11 is dated for the Day 15 batch.

DAY 19 Handle replies properly

OBJECTIVE	Turn conversations into a yes, a later, or a clean close.
TASK	Reply to every message received so far the same day. Use script 6 for price, script 7 for not now. Send five new first messages.
EXAMPLE	Someone writes send it and we will see. You offer one small free sample and quote the full package.
OUTPUT	Zero unanswered messages at the end of the day.
CHECK	☐ Every reply has a clear next step in it. ☐ Nobody is waiting on you.

DAY 20 Follow-up 1 on the second batch

OBJECTIVE	Keep every batch moving on schedule.
TASK	Send follow-up 1 to the Day 16 and Day 17 batches. Send five new first messages.
EXAMPLE	Selam, following up briefly. Here is the sample I mentioned — if the timing is wrong, tell me and I will not bother you again.
OUTPUT	Thirty messages sent in total across the month.
CHECK	☐ Thirty rows have a first-message date. ☐ No row has been messaged twice on the same day.

DAY 21 Catch-up and count

OBJECTIVE	Know your real numbers rather than your impression of them.
TASK	Finish any missed messages. Count four things: messages sent, replies received, conversations still open, and anything agreed.
EXAMPLE	Thirty sent, four replied, two still talking, none agreed. That is a normal first week of outreach, not a failure.
OUTPUT	Four numbers written in your Admin folder with the date.
CHECK	☐ Thirty messages sent, or a written reason why not. ☐ Every open conversation has a next action dated within three days.

DAY 22 Follow-up 2 and the referral ask

OBJECTIVE	Reopen the quiet ones with a smaller offer, and ask for introductions.
TASK	Send follow-up 2 (script 4) offering the smaller package to the Day 15 batch. Ask every warm contact for one introduction using script 8.
EXAMPLE	If the full package is more than you want to spend now, I can start with six photos and a price list for $8 instead.
OUTPUT	Five follow-ups and at least one referral request sent.
CHECK	☐ The smaller option has a real, lower price. ☐ Referral requests were made without pressure.

10.5 Days 23 to 30 — deliver, get paid, decide

DAY 23 Onboard whoever said yes

OBJECTIVE	Turn a yes into a written scope and a first payment.
TASK	Send the onboarding and scope message from section 09 to everybody who agreed. If nobody has agreed yet, send ten more first messages and five follow-ups instead.
EXAMPLE	Deliverables, formats, what is not included, price, payment split, timeline, revision round, wallet number.
OUTPUT	One scope message sent per agreed job, or fifteen further outreach messages.
CHECK	☐ No job starts without a written scope. ☐ Every open prospect has been contacted again this week.

DAY 24 Do the work — milestone one

OBJECTIVE	Produce the first visible piece so the client is not waiting in silence.
TASK	Complete the first milestone and send it for a look. Continue five outreach messages a day regardless.
EXAMPLE	Twelve photos shot, the best eight edited and sent as compressed previews for selection.
OUTPUT	A milestone sent and five new messages.
CHECK	☐ The client has something in hand. ☐ Prospecting did not stop because you got busy.

DAY 25 Finish and deliver

OBJECTIVE	Complete files in the client's hands, in usable formats.
TASK	Finish the work, organise the folder, check the sharing link, and send the delivery message from section 09.
EXAMPLE	Print-ready PDF, PNG versions for social, and a note that revisions are due within three days as one message.
OUTPUT	A delivery message sent with a working link.
CHECK	☐ The link opens for somebody who is not you. ☐ The balance and the payment route are in the same message.

DAY 26 Revisions and invoice

OBJECTIVE Close the revision round and put the money on paper.

TASK Make the included revision round. Send the invoice wording from section 09 with a due date.

EXAMPLE Invoice 001, work: cafe menu package, total $16, paid $1,250, balance $1,250 due Friday.

OUTPUT Revisions delivered and an invoice sent.

CHECK

- [ ] The invoice has a number, a date and a due date.
- [ ] A copy is saved in the client folder.

DAY 27 Payment, then the testimonial

OBJECTIVE Money confirmed, and one honest sentence you can reuse.

TASK Confirm the balance landed in your wallet. Then ask for a testimonial and permission to show the work.

EXAMPLE When you are happy with it, would you send me one or two sentences about the work? I would like to show it as a sample, with your permission.

OUTPUT Payment confirmed and a testimonial requested.

CHECK

- [ ] The amount received matches the invoice.
- [ ] You asked for permission before using the work.

DAY 28 Catch-up and final follow-ups

OBJECTIVE Clear the list honestly before the month ends.

TASK Send the final follow-up (script 5) to anybody who never replied, then mark those rows Closed. Finish any outstanding delivery or revision work.

EXAMPLE I will stop following up after this message. If this becomes useful later, my number is unchanged and the samples stay here.

OUTPUT Every row in the tracker has a status that is not blank.

CHECK

- [ ] No row is left in an undefined state.
- [ ] Closed rows are closed, not forgotten.

DAY 29 Review the month with numbers

OBJECTIVE	Find out what actually worked, using figures rather than feelings.
TASK	Write six numbers: messages sent, replies, conversations, jobs agreed, jobs delivered, USD received. Then write which message got the best response.
EXAMPLE	Forty-two sent, nine replies, four conversations, one job, one delivered, $1,250 received.
OUTPUT	One page of numbers and one page of what to repeat.
CHECK	☐ The numbers come from the tracker, not memory. ☐ You named one thing to stop doing and one to do twice as much.

DAY 30 Plan the next thirty days

OBJECTIVE	Month two should not start from zero.
TASK	Ask every delivered client whether they want the same work monthly. Add fifteen new prospects. Write the next thirty-day plan using the numbers from Day 29.
EXAMPLE	Would you like me to keep the menu and photos updated monthly? It would be $9 a month for four new photos and any price changes.
OUTPUT	Monthly offers sent, fifteen new prospects added, next month planned.
CHECK	☐ Every happy client was asked the monthly question. ☐ The prospect list never drops to zero.

11

AFTER THE FIRST JOB

Testimonials, Repeat Business and Reinvesting

How to ask for a testimonial honestly, turn one job into a monthly client, and spend the first money on things that produce the second payment.

01 Asking for a testimonial

02 One client into a monthly client

03 What to reinvest in

04 What not to buy

The first payment is a milestone. The second payment from the same client is a business.

This short section covers the three habits that separate readers who earn once from readers who keep earning: collecting honest proof, asking for the repeat, and spending the first money on capacity rather than on appearance.

11.1 Asking for a testimonial legitimately

A testimonial is a sentence from a real client about real work, used with their permission. Everything else is fabrication, and fabrication in a small market is a bad trade.

— **Ask at the moment of satisfaction**, which is the same day you deliver and they respond positively. A week later the feeling has faded.

— **Ask for something specific.** Not are you happy, but could you write two sentences about how the new menu photos compare with the old ones?

— **Remove the effort.** Offer to draft nothing. If they prefer, ask them to send a voice note and you transcribe it word for word, then send it back for approval.

— **Ask permission separately** for showing the work itself. A testimonial and permission to publish the deliverable are two different agreements.

> **NEVER WRITE IT YOURSELF**
>
> Do not write a testimonial and ask the client to sign it. Do not invent one. Do not edit one so heavily that it says something the client did not say. Do not screenshot a private message and publish it without asking.
>
> If a client will not give you a testimonial, you have two honest options: use the delivered work with their permission and no quote, or use nothing. A portfolio with three real samples and no testimonials is worth more than one with a quote you wrote.

11.2 Turning one client into a monthly client

Monthly work is the difference between finding a job every month and running a small practice. Convert on the day you deliver, while the work is on their screen.

COPY-READY: THE MONTHLY OFFER

Glad you are happy with it. One thing worth mentioning: most of what I did here goes stale — prices change, new dishes arrive, photos get old.

I can keep it updated for **[monthly price]** USD a month: **[four new photos, any price changes, one new post a week]**. You would pay on the first working day of the month and I would send a short note at the end of each month saying what was done.

No obligation either way. Would that be useful?

Two things make this work. First, the monthly scope is countable, so the client knows what arrives. Second, the price is lower than a standalone repeat job, because you are removing your own prospecting cost.

PROTECT YOURSELF ON MONTHLY WORK

Agree the payment date, not only the amount. If payment is more than one cycle late, pause the work and say so plainly: I will restart as soon as the month is settled. Continuing to deliver unpaid work for three months is not patience, it is a subsidy.

11.3 What to reinvest the first money in

The first payment is not profit. It is working capital. Spend it on whatever most increases the chance of the next payment.

ORDER	WHAT TO BUY	WHY IT COMES FIRST
1	A data bundle	Nothing else in this list works without connectivity. Bundle prices are indicative and change, so buy what you will actually use.
2	A phone tripod or clamp	Steadier photographs and video, which is the fastest visible quality gain in product and food work.
3	A domain name, if your work is online-facing	Gives you a stable address for a portfolio. Verify current prices and renewal terms before buying.
4	Saving toward registration	A trade licence and TIN open merchant gateways, larger clients and formal contracts. Treat this as a medium-term goal, not a month-one purchase.
5	A cheap lighting solution	A white board or a sheet as a reflector costs almost nothing and improves every future shoot.

11.4 What not to buy

— **Paid advertising before you have proof.** Ads amplify a message that works. They do not fix an offer nobody wants.

— **A laptop on credit in month one.** Nothing in this book requires one. Buy it from profit, not from hope.

— **Paid courses that promise clients.** Nobody can promise you clients. The free government-backed digital skills programme had more than five million enrolments by June 2026, so free structured learning exists.

— **A premium tool subscription you use twice.** Free tiers are enough for the first month's work.

— **Anything paid for in crypto.** Virtual-asset activity is prohibited where you live unless expressly authorised, and a seller demanding crypto is a warning sign, not a convenience.

12

PERSPECTIVE

How $500 Actually Looks in Real Life

What $500 buys where you live in September 2026, what it does and does not change, and why people still pay for structure when free training exists.

01 What $500 is worth

02 What it does change

03 What it does not change

04 Why people pay for structure

A number without context tends to get overestimated. This section puts $500 next to ordinary local prices so you can see exactly what size of thing it is.

Every figure here is sourced and current as of September 2026. Where a figure is an estimate rather than a measurement, it says so.

12.1 What $500 is worth

ONE CONVERSION, WITH ITS RATE AND DATE

`$500 ÷ 161.10 = about USD 62`

At $161.10 per USD on 11 September 2026, with the dollars down about 11.8% year on year. This is the only currency conversion in this book.

$500 COMPARED WITH	FIGURE	WHAT IT MEANS
Federal civil service, degree-holder entry pay	$70 / month	Slightly less than one month of entry-level graduate government pay, raised from $45 in September 2025.
Commercial bakery loaf, 75 to 80 g	$0.10	Everyday prices in your own market are the clearest inflation signal, which is inflation you can hold in your hand.
Ordinary paperback novel	$3	About 22 books, in a market where the range runs roughly 350 to $4 and the local language e-book is around $1.25.
Mobile data, 30 GB monthly bundle	About $5	Roughly twelve months of a 30 GB bundle at indicative pricing, or a little over three months at the high-usage freelancer figure of up to $19 a month.
Industrial-park garment worker	About $11 / month	More than five months of that wage, for comparison with the least-paid formal work.
Young urban white-collar work in Addis, planning estimate	6,000 to $15,000 / month	$500 sits inside the middle of this estimate, which is exactly why it is a meaningful first target rather than a fantasy.

Sources are listed in the Sources & Further Reading section. The 6,000 to $15,000 band is a planning estimate, not a survey. your country has no universal statutory minimum wage for the private sector, and job boards do not publish salaries.

THE CONTEXT THAT MATTERS MOST

Headline inflation was 15.1% year on year in August 2026. **Education inflation was 25.3%**, the fastest-rising non-food item. Any money you earn and hold loses value; any skill you build is priced against a rising market. That is an argument for earning sooner and learning continuously, not for waiting until you feel ready.

12.2 What it does change

— **It proves the route works.** A single delivered job and a payment received is evidence that somebody where you live will pay you money for work you did on a phone. That evidence is worth more than the amount.

— **It changes how you introduce yourself.** I do menu photography for cafes is a different sentence from I am learning design.
— **It produces a reference.** One client who will answer a phone call about you is an asset that does not expire quickly.
— **It buys capacity.** Data, a tripod, a saved deposit toward registration — each one raises the ceiling on the next month.
— **It changes the next conversation.** The second client takes less effort than the first, and the tenth takes less than the second.

12.3 What it does not change

$500 is a proof of concept, not a new life. It does not cover a year of rent, it does not replace a salary, and it does not mean next month will be the same or better. Readers who treat one good month as a permanent state usually stop prospecting, and then month three arrives with nothing in it.

It also does not arrive on schedule. Some readers will finish thirty days with a delivered job and a payment. Some will finish with a scope message sent and a first conversation open. Some will finish with nothing but a list, an offer and forty sent messages. All three are legitimate first months, and the third is often the beginning of the second month's income.

> **SAY IT PLAINLY**
>
> **$500 is a target example, not a guarantee, not a prediction and not a promise.** Many readers will earn less in thirty days. Some will earn nothing in month one. The purpose of the number was never to be hit; it was to make the arithmetic concrete enough that you could act on it.

12.4 Why people still pay for structure

your country has a free, government-backed digital skills programme that had reached **5,005,146 enrolments by June 2026**, with the target raised to seven million. A private in-person digital skills course costs around **$125** — about double the target in this book — and has been described as far beyond the reach of most families.

If free training exists at that scale, why would anybody pay? Because access and completion are different problems. A free library of courses gives you material and leaves you to supply the sequence, the deadline and the accountability. Most people do not finish unstructured material, and the people who do are usually the ones who did not need it.

What you paid for with this book is not information. It is an order of operations, a set of scripts, a thirty-day calendar and a decision you were pushed to make on Day 1. That is the honest case for structure: not that the knowledge is secret, but that **the sequence is what most people cannot build for themselves under pressure.**

> **THE ONLY REAL TEST**
>
> You will know within thirty days whether this approach suits you, and you will know it from evidence you produced yourself: messages sent, replies received, work delivered, money received. Not from how motivated you feel. Feelings are a poor instrument; a tracker is a good one.

Common Mistakes, and the Fix for Each

These are the twelve failures that end most first attempts. Each one has a specific fix you can apply today.

MISTAKE	WHY IT KILLS THE MONTH	THE FIX
1. Running three paths at once	No single path gets enough hours to produce a result, so all three look like failures.	Score the eight paths, choose one, and write the other seven into a file you will not open until Day 31.
2. Building the portfolio for three weeks	Preparation feels productive and produces no conversations. Outreach is the only activity that can produce a client.	Cap preparation at Day 14. Send your first five messages on Day 15 regardless of how the samples look.
3. Pricing at zero to get started	Free clients rarely convert to paying ones, and free work signals that your time has no value.	Start at a low but real price, state that it is a one-time introductory price, and ask for a testimonial in exchange.
4. Writing a first line about yourself	The reader decides in one line whether to read the second, and I am a designer gives them no reason to.	Open with a specific observation about their business. Your offer comes second.
5. Sending one message and stopping	Most replies arrive after a follow-up, so a single message measures nothing except your patience.	Use the three-follow-up rule over fifteen days, then close the row and move on.
6. No written scope	Both sides remember the agreement differently, and the difference always costs you money.	Send the scope message within an hour of the yes: deliverables, formats, exclusions, price, split, timeline, revisions.
7. Unlimited revisions	One job quietly becomes four, and the hourly rate collapses below anything you would have accepted.	One round, sent as a single message within three days, with a stated price for further rounds.

MISTAKE	WHY IT KILLS THE MONTH	THE FIX
8. Starting work before the deposit	You carry all the risk, and clients who never intended to pay get a free deliverable.	Start when the first payment arrives. For sub-$3 jobs, take the full amount on delivery instead.
9. Delivering and disappearing	You lose the testimonial, the repeat job and the referral — the three cheapest sources of next month's income.	Ask for a testimonial the day they are happy, and ask the monthly question in the same conversation.
10. Believing a platform payout is coming	your country is not on the YouTube Partner Program list, TikTok Creator Rewards has no African markets, and Meta in-stream ads did not include your country. Waiting for ad money is waiting for a payment that may never exist.	Build income on services, products, sponsorships, lead generation, consulting or community. Verify any platform claim inside your own account.
11. Building a plan on one big client	More than 80% of federal business licences issued went dormant during 2025. Your one client is a small business in a fragile market.	Keep the prospect list alive every week, even when you are busy. Aim for several smaller clients rather than one whale.

MISTAKE	WHY IT KILLS THE MONTH	THE FIX
12. Buying a tool or course to feel ready	Spending replaces the uncomfortable part — contacting strangers — with a comfortable one.	Buy nothing in month one except data. Free tiers are enough, and the free government-backed programme already had more than five million enrolments by June 2026.

MISTAKE	WHY IT KILLS THE MONTH	THE FIX
13. Trusting a job that requires a fee, an OTP or crypto	These are the three reliable signatures of a scam in this market.	Stop the conversation. Nobody legitimate asks for your one-time code, a payment to unlock work, or settlement in virtual assets.

MISTAKE	WHY IT KILLS THE MONTH	THE FIX
14. Reading the whole book first	You finish with knowledge and no assets, which is the most expensive outcome available.	Do Day 1 today. Then read the next day's page.

Frequently Asked Questions

I only have a phone. Can I do this?

Yes. Every workflow in this book was written phone-first. Prospecting, outreach, design, delivery and receiving payment all work on an Android phone. A laptop makes two things faster — bulk photo editing and long documents — and neither is required to earn a first payment.

Do I need a business licence?

No, not to receive money for services as an individual. A personal wallet or bank transfer works inside the your central bank or financial regulator Level 2 limits. You do need a registered business — trade licence, TIN and Memorandum of Association — if you want a merchant payment gateway such as a local card-and-wallet gateway, a local payment gateway, a local payment gateway or a local payment gateway, because none of them is verified to onboard unlicensed individuals. Larger corporate clients will also usually require a licence and a TIN before they can pay you.

How do I get paid by a foreign client?

Through your regulator-licensed remittance corridor. Your client sends money through a licensed operator such as Western Union, MoneyGram, Ria, Remitly, WorldRemit, Taptap Send, TalkRemit, Xpress Money, Transfast, Thunes or Alansari, or through a wallet corridor such as a wallet remittance corridor, a wallet remittance corridor or a mobile-money wallet. You collect in dollars as cash, a bank deposit or wallet credit. **There is no verified direct PayPal, Payoneer, Wise or Stripe receiving rail for a resident of a country with limited payment access.** Do not fake your location or rent somebody else's account to work around that.

What if nobody replies?

Check four things in order: volume, first line, channel and ask. Thirty messages is a small sample; eight is not a sample at all. If your first ten messages could have been sent to any business, they were not personalised. If Telegram gets nothing, try a phone call or a walk-in. And make sure every message ends with a small, specific next step rather than a vague expression of interest.

Is this a scam?

This book does not ask you for money beyond its purchase price, does not promise income, does not tell you to recruit anybody, and does not route you into crypto or an unlicensed scheme. Those four things are the standard anatomy of an online-income scam, and you should apply the same test to every other offer you receive. If somebody promises a figure, pay attention to how quickly they ask for a fee.

How long before I earn anything?

Nobody can tell you, and anybody who gives you a date is guessing or selling. What can be said honestly: month one is mostly setup, proof and outreach, and paid work often arrives late in it or in month two. Local services tend to produce a first payment faster than freelancing or content, because you can meet the buyer.

Do I need perfect English?

No. You need English clear enough to be understood, and you need to be honest about what you can write in. Many local businesses prefer the local language anyway. Use an AI chat tool to check a draft, but read every word before you send it, and never send a paragraph you do not understand.

Will this work outside your city?

Yes, and competition is thinner. The method is the same: one area, one category, twenty listings, one observation each. a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city and a regional city all have enough listed businesses to build a list of thirty. Budgets are often smaller, so size the package to the local market.

What about tax?

A TIN is mandatory. Turnover Tax is 2% on goods sold locally and 10% on other services, and where VAT applies, turnover tax does not. VAT registration may be cancelled if taxable transactions over twelve months are expected to be $500,000 or less, and records must be kept for ten years. Presumptive or Category C details are not verified here — confirm your own position at your local tax office. This book is not tax advice.

How much should I charge for my first job?

Price the deliverable, not your time. Give one number, not a range. Use a low but real introductory price, say out loud that it is introductory, and ask for a testimonial and permission to show the work in exchange. Raise the price for new clients after three finished jobs.

Can I do this while studying or working full time?

The calendar assumes 60 to 90 minutes a day. Students and employed readers finish it, usually by protecting a fixed hour — early morning works better than late night because outreach needs to land during business hours. What does not work is treating the plan as something to do when everything else is finished.

What if the internet is slow, restricted or shut down?

Plan for it. your country has a documented history of internet disruptions, including a nationwide block of several platforms for about five months in 2023 and regional shutdowns since. Work text-first, keep drafts on the phone, download what you need in advance, and keep phone numbers for your active clients so you can call instead of message. A business that only exists on one platform is fragile.

Do I have to show my face online?

No. Plenty of service work — menu design, product photos, caption writing, page management — requires no personal video. A clear profile photo helps people trust you, and it can be a simple, professional head-and-shoulders shot. Content creation on camera is one path of eight, not a requirement for the other seven.

Should I buy a course that guarantees clients?

No. Nobody can guarantee clients, and the guarantee is the sales technique rather than the product. If you want more structured learning, note that a free government-backed programme had more than five million enrolments by June 2026, and that a private in-person course costs around $125. Buy structure if it helps you finish — never buy a promise.

How to Spot a Fake Opportunity

This market contains real work and real fraud side by side. The fraud follows patterns, and the patterns are recognisable once you know them.

The documented risks

Impersonation and urgent transfer requests. The your central bank or financial regulator has issued a public warning that fraudsters impersonate people on WhatsApp, Telegram, Facebook, email, SMS and through fake phone calls in order to request urgent transfers of money. The warning sits alongside Proclamation 1359/2025 and the your financial-consumer-protection rules. If you are targeted, your regulator directs reports to `your regulator's complaint address` or to the short code 6230.

Telegram account takeover. local press has documented a specific scam in which criminals pose as Telegram security staff, persuade the victim to hand over a password and a one-time code, seize the account, and then message the victim's contacts asking for money in their name. The damage is not only financial; it is your reputation inside your own network.

The fee-to-unlock scam. A job is offered, then a registration fee, a training fee, a clearance fee or a delivery fee appears. Sometimes the amount is small, which is the point. Legitimate work does not charge you for the right to do it.

Crypto and virtual-asset schemes. The your regulator issued a public notice on 23 July 2026 drawing a red line on virtual assets and cautioning the public against unregulated digital transactions. Virtual-asset activity is prohibited where you live unless expressly authorised. Any opportunity that pays, stakes or settles in crypto is outside that line, whatever the returns quoted.

Unlicensed remittance. Acting as, or using, an unlicensed money remittance route is illegal and punishable. If a client or an agent asks you to receive money for somebody else and pass it on, that is not a favour, it is an offence.

The eight-point legitimacy checklist

Run every opportunity — a job, a client, an agent, a platform — through these eight questions before you commit anything.

- [ ] Nobody has asked for my one-time code. If anybody does, the answer is no, and the conversation is over.
- [ ] I was not asked to pay a fee to unlock work, training, clearance or delivery.
- [ ] The urgency is not manufactured. Real clients accept that you will reply tomorrow.
- [ ] The payment route is a licensed one — a wallet or bank in dollars domestically, or a licensed remittance corridor from abroad.
- [ ] Nothing in the arrangement involves crypto, virtual assets or tokens.
- [ ] The person or business can be verified independently: a listing, an address, a registration number, a call back on a number I already had.
- [ ] The offer does not depend on recruiting other people.
- [ ] The promised figure is plausible for the work described. If the pay is far above the market for a task anybody could do, the money is coming from somewhere else in the scheme.

TWO RULES THAT COVER MOST OF IT

Never share a one-time code with anybody, for any reason. No legitimate platform, bank, employer or client asks for it.

Never pay to receive work. Money moves towards the person doing the work, always. The moment that reverses, you are the customer of a scam, not the contractor of a job.

Sources & Further Reading

Every platform figure in this book traces to one of the sources below, all checked in September 2026. Platform country lists, payout methods and fees change often — confirm anything you intend to rely on at the source itself.

1. Gumroad — pricing and fee structure — https://gumroad.com/pricing
2. Gumroad — getting paid, bank-payout country list and payout schedule — https://gumroad.com/help/article/13-getting-paid
3. Gumroad — fees in detail — https://gumroad.com/help/article/66-gumroads-fees
4. Gumroad — payout settings, identity documents and tax IDs — https://gumroad.com/help/article/260-your-payout-settings-page
5. Gumroad — account suspension and what causes it — https://gumroad.com/help/article/160-suspension
6. Gumroad — terms of service (identity, location and account rules) — https://gumroad.com/terms
7. Lemon Squeezy — supported countries for sellers — https://docs.lemonsqueezy.com/help/getting-started/supported-countries
8. Lemon Squeezy — W-8 and W-9 tax forms for non-US sellers — https://docs.lemonsqueezy.com/help/tax-forms/w8-w9-forms
9. Lemon Squeezy — pricing — https://www.lemonsqueezy.com/pricing
10. Stripe — cross-border payouts and supported regions — https://docs.stripe.com/connect/cross-border-payouts
11. IRS — About Form W-8BEN — https://www.irs.gov/forms-pubs/about-form-w-8-ben
12. IRS — United States income tax treaties A to Z — https://www.irs.gov/businesses/international-businesses/united-states-income-tax-treaties-a-to-z
13. Whop — payout methods and countries — https://docs.whop.com/manage-your-business/manage-payouts/payout-methods
14. Payhip — how sellers get paid — https://help.payhip.com/article/173-how-do-i-get-paid
15. Ko-fi — how creators get paid — https://help.ko-fi.com/hc/en-us/articles/115003980093-How-do-I-get-paid
16. Fungies — countries you can sell from — https://fungies.io/global-availability/
17. Telegram — Telegram Stars for digital goods — https://telegram.org/blog/telegram-stars
18. Google — Business Profile supported countries — https://support.google.com/business/answer/6270107
19. YouTube — Partner Program availability by country — https://support.google.com/youtube/answer/7101720
20. DataReportal — global digital statistics — https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-global-overview-report
21. World Bank — World Development Indicators — https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators
22. International Labour Organization — ILOSTAT employment data — https://ilostat.ilo.org/
23. Internet Society — Internet shutdown and disruption reporting — https://www.internetsociety.org/
24. FATF — virtual asset and payment-service guidance by jurisdiction — https://www.fatf-gafi.org/

Where research could not verify a fact, this book says so in the text and tells you to check it yourself. Those gaps were left as gaps deliberately.

Final Checklist

Twenty-five items. If every line is ticked, you have a working practice rather than a plan.

DECISION AND SETUP

- [ ] The eight-criteria worksheet is complete and one path is chosen.
- [ ] The other seven paths are written in a Later file and closed for thirty days.
- [ ] A Google account exists with two-step verification switched on.
- [ ] The email address is one you would print on an invoice.
- [ ] Drive folders exist: Work Samples, Clients, Admin.
- [ ] Telegram has a username, a clear photo and a one-line bio.
- [ ] Telegram has Clients and Prospects folders and two-step verification on.
- [ ] The wallet is open, the daily limits are known, and two-factor authentication is on.

OFFER AND PROOF

- [ ] The offer exists in writing with one price, one deadline and countable deliverables.
- [ ] The offer states what is not included.
- [ ] Three sample projects exist, each in a different business category.
- [ ] Every sample carries the sample label in the image, the file name and the folder description.
- [ ] One before-and-after pair exists and does not criticise a named business.
- [ ] The one-page work sample PDF opens on a phone.
- [ ] The how-I-work one-pager states the revision round and the payment split.

PROSPECTS AND OUTREACH

- [ ] The tracker has fifteen headers and thirty named rows.
- [ ] Every row has one specific observation, not a generic compliment.
- [ ] At least thirty first messages have been sent, with dates recorded.
- [ ] Every prospect who did not reply received three follow-ups and was then closed.
- [ ] Every reply received a same-day answer with a clear next step.
- [ ] At least two businesses were visited in person.
- [ ] At least one referral was requested.

DELIVERY, PAYMENT AND REPEAT

- [ ] No job started without a written scope message.
- [ ] Every delivered job has an invoice with a number, a date and a due date.
- [ ] Every satisfied client was asked for a testimonial and the monthly question.

> **IF YOU TICKED FEWER THAN FIFTEEN**
>
> That is information, not a verdict. Count which block is thinnest and finish that block this week. In most cases it is outreach: readers complete the setup beautifully and then avoid the messages, because the messages are the only part where somebody can say no.

Final Challenge: Launch Your First Income Path in 7 Days

If the thirty-day calendar felt long, this is the compressed version. Seven days, one path, one offer, one sample, fifteen prospects and ten sent messages.

WHAT THIS CHALLENGE DOES AND DOES NOT DO

Completing this challenge does not guarantee income. It guarantees that you finish the week with a chosen path, a written offer, a labelled sample, a prospect list and ten sent messages. Those five things are what a paying client is built on. Whether a payment arrives in week two or week eight depends on your market, your category and how many conversations you keep open.

DAY 1 Choose the path and write the offer

TASK	Score the eight paths using the worksheet in section 02. Choose one. Write the five-sentence offer from section 04.
EXAMPLE	Local digital services for cafes in the commercial district: twelve dish photos and a one-page menu with prices, $16, half before and half on delivery, four days after the shoot.
OUTPUT	A circled path and one written offer.
CHECK	☐ One price, one deadline, countable deliverables.

DAY 2 Identity and tracker

TASK	Create or clean the Google account, set two-step verification, set a Telegram username and bio, and build the tracker with the fifteen headers.
EXAMPLE	Bio: Menu design and product photos for cafes in Addis. DM or call 09xx xxx xxx.
OUTPUT	A professional identity and an empty tracker ready for rows.
CHECK	☐ A friend can tell what you do from your profile alone.

DAY 3 Build one labelled sample

TASK Shoot and finish one sample project by a window on a plain background. Label it as a sample in the image, the file name and the folder description.

EXAMPLE Twelve dish photos and a one-page menu, labelled Sample — created by [your name] for demonstration.

OUTPUT One finished sample with a working share link.

CHECK

- [ ] The link opens for somebody who is not you.
- [ ] Nothing implies a real client.

DAY 4 Fifteen prospects

TASK Open Google Maps. One area, one category. Open twenty listings and write fifteen rows with one specific observation each.

EXAMPLE the central district, cafes: no prices on the listing, last post five months ago, photos taken at night.

OUTPUT Fifteen rows with contact routes and observations.

CHECK

- [ ] No two observations are the same sentence.

DAY 5 Send ten messages

TASK Send ten first messages to the strongest rows, five in the morning and five in the afternoon. Record the date for each.

EXAMPLE Selam, I saw your menu photos are from 2023 and there are no prices on the listing. I photograph food and build menu layouts for small cafes in Addis.

OUTPUT Ten sent messages and ten dated rows.

CHECK

- [ ] Every first line is specific to that business.
- [ ] Every message ends with a clear next step.

DAY 6 Follow up, and go outside

TASK Answer every reply the same day. Visit three businesses from your list in person with the sample on your phone.

EXAMPLE Walk in at 15:00, ask for the owner by name, show the before-and-after pair, ask for a phone number.

OUTPUT Three in-person conversations recorded with next actions.

CHECK

- [ ] No message is left unanswered.
- [ ] Every visit produced a name or a number.

DAY 7 **Review and set week two**

TASK	Count messages sent, replies received and conversations open. Then write what you will do twice as much next week.
EXAMPLE	Ten sent, two replied, one still talking. Next week: twenty sent, follow-ups on all ten, one more walk-in round.
OUTPUT	A one-page week-two plan in your Admin folder.
CHECK	☐ The numbers come from the tracker. ☐ Every open conversation has a dated next action.

Next Steps

This book got you to one chosen path and a first set of conversations. The next course depends on which path you chose.

If you chose freelancing

Continue with **Course 02 — Freelancing from a country with limited payment access**. It goes deeper into profiles, proposals, client communication and the payment routes that work for foreign clients, at the level of detail this introductory book could not carry.

If you chose AI-assisted services

Continue with **Course 03 — AI-Assisted Services**. It covers using AI tools as production capacity rather than as a shortcut, with quality control, disclosure and the pricing that goes with faster delivery.

If you chose local digital services

Continue with **Course 09 — Local Business Services**. It goes further into menus, listings, Google Business Profile work, in-person selling and the retainer conversations that turn one job into a monthly client.

If you want the full programme

Course 10 — the full implementation programme runs the whole system end to end across a longer period, with the review cycles and accountability checkpoints that the thirty-day calendar compresses.

One last instruction, and it is the same one this book opened with. Write down the next physical action you will take, with a time attached to it. Not the goal. The action. Open the tracker at 19:00. Send five messages at 10:00. Walk into two shops on Saturday morning.

THE END OF THE BOOK, THE START OF THE WORK

Do not close this file and feel that you have learned something. The only measure that counts is the one you can point to: a list, a message, a delivered file, a payment. Everything else in these pages was preparation for one of those four things.

Practical digital skills and income systems built for your country.

NexKit your country publishes short, specific, honest courses for readers who want to earn with the phone in their hand and the market they actually live in. No guarantees, no invented proof, no hype. Only the sequence, the scripts and the arithmetic.

02 Freelancing from a country with limited payment access

03 AI-Assisted Services

09 Local Business Services

10 The Full Implementation Programme

FINAL CHALLENGE

Final Challenge: Launch Your First Income Path in 7 Days

You have read twelve sections. This is the part that decides whether any of it was real.

01 Choose your path. Score all eight with the Opportunity Score worksheet and write the winner on paper.

02 Write your offer. Under 90 words, with a price in dollars, a countable deliverable and a delivery time.

03 Build one piece of proof. A before-and-after, a sample package, or a one-page "how I work" sheet. Every piece labelled as sample work.

04 Build a list of twenty named prospects with a phone number and one written observation each.

05 Send eight conversations and personalise the first line of every one of them.

06 Send eight more, and follow up every Day-5 message that has not been answered.

07 Ask every warm prospect one closing question with a date in it, and record the result in your tracker.

Seven days will not produce $500 for most people, and this page does not claim it will. What seven days will produce is one offer, one piece of proof, twenty named prospects and sixteen real conversations. That is the machine. Everything after it is repetition.

It is a structured exercise, not a promise. What it produces is a working asset you can run again at higher volume.

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How to Make Your First $500 Online

A 30-Day Zero-Budget Action Plan

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Before You Spend a Dollars on Anything

How to Make Your First $500 Online where you live — 30-Day Zero-Budget Action Plan. First Edition · September 2026.

Publisher: NexKit your country Editorial Team. This course was researched, written and edited by the NexKit your country Editorial Team. It carries no individual author name and no personal credentials, because the value of the book is the method, not a personality.

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What this course is

A practical, your country-specific action plan. It describes eight realistic ways people in this country earn money online, gives you a scoring worksheet to choose one, and then walks you through thirty days of setup, proof, prospecting, outreach, delivery and payment.

It is written for a reader with a smartphone, a modest data bundle, no business licence, no TIN, no merchant account, no PayPal and no international card. Every workflow in it has a phone path and, where it helps, a laptop path.

What this course is not

It is not a promise of income. It is not legal advice, tax advice or investment advice. It is not a list of guaranteed clients, guaranteed platform approvals or guaranteed results, and it does not contain a single invented testimonial or earnings screenshot.

It cannot tell you what a bank, a wallet provider, a platform or a government office will decide about your specific case. That depends on your documents, your record and the rules in force on the day you apply.

DISCLAIMER — READ THIS ONCE, PROPERLY

This course is **educational material only**. Nothing in it is a guarantee of income, and nothing in it is financial, legal or investment advice.

$500 is a target, not a prediction. It exists to make the arithmetic concrete and to give you a way to keep score for thirty days. Many readers will earn less than that in the first month. Some will earn nothing in month one and their first income in month two. A smaller number will earn more. None of those outcomes is a verdict on you.

All prices, rates and ladders shown in this book are **illustrative examples** for teaching. You are responsible for complying with local law, your tax obligations, the terms of service of any platform you use, and the requirements of any bank, wallet or payment provider you deal with. Rules, fees, limits and country availability change, sometimes quickly.

Where the underlying research could not verify a fact, this book says so and tells you to check it yourself. Those gaps were left as gaps deliberately.

DATES, CURRENCY AND EXAMPLES

All money in this course is US US dollars (USD), written as $25. There is exactly one conversion to United States dollars in the whole book, in section 12, and it states its rate and its date on the same line.

Every business named anywhere in these pages is invented. Each is labelled **Example scenario — fictional**. No real, recognisable local company is presented as a client, a case study or a testimonial.

Every figure cited is current as of **September 2026** unless a different date is printed beside it. Source URLs for those figures appear in the **Sources & Further Reading** section at the back of the book.

BEFORE YOU RELY ON ANY OF THIS

Payment limits, wallet rules, tax thresholds and platform availability are the parts of this book most likely to go stale. Treat the numbers as a starting point for your own check, not as a substitute for it. Where this book names a rule, confirm the current version with the institution that made it.

Last updated: September 2026. Questions or corrections: use the contact address supplied with your purchase.

What is inside this course

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HOW TO WORK THROUGH THIS COURSE

Skim the section dividers first so you can see the whole route. Then work one section at a time and finish the **DO** tasks before moving to the next. The scripts, templates and checklists are meant to be copied, filled in and sent — not admired.